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Chapter 1

Mecca

First, let us look at a few things about Mecca.

Before Islam, Mecca was the central city of Arabia. It was founded by Abraham about five thousand years ago. Abraham's original city was Nasiriyah, about one hundred miles from Basra. His father, Terah, was a mason there and built houses for people. Later, in connection with their work, father and son, together with the rest of the family, moved to the city of Ur. Its ruins still exist today, about sixty to seventy kilometres northeast of Karbala. The city of Nimrod was situated near Babylon, although the city of Babylon itself did not yet exist at that time.

At the centre of Nimrod's city stood a great temple of the priests, the tallest structure in the city. The chief priest there was named Azar. It was through his guarantee and patronage that Abraham and his father were allowed to live and work in the city. For this reason, the Qur'an referred to Azar as Abraham's *ab*, meaning his guardian or patron. He was not Abraham's father, as is commonly assumed. In Arabic, a father is called *walid*, not *ab*.

When Abraham came into conflict with the people of the city over idol worship, they decided to burn him in the fire. He survived, however, and, taking his father and his tribe with him, travelled through different lands until they reached what is now Palestine.

While they were in western Jordan, a king gave Abraham's wife Sarah a maidservant named Hagar. Sarah had no children. After some time, she told Abraham to marry Hagar in the hope that he might have a child. Abraham did so, and a son was born to them. He was named Ishmael. Soon afterward, however, Sarah also conceived and Isaac was born. Sarah then found it difficult to continue living with Hagar, so Abraham brought Hagar and Ishmael to the place now known as Mecca. It is possible that Abraham had passed through this place before and already knew its importance.

Mecca lay on the route taken by trading caravans travelling to Syria, Yemen, Abyssinia, and other regions. Many Arab tribes were already settled in Arabia. Ishmael married into a tribe of Jurhum from Yemen. The woman's name was Sayyidah bint Mudad. Ishmael had twelve sons, who spread into other parts of Arabia. Among their descendants was a son named Nadr ibn Malik, who gathered together scattered people. For this reason he received the title Quraysh. He remained in Mecca and made hunting and trade his occupations.

Although people from other tribes also lived in Mecca and its surrounding areas, they were neither numerous nor strong in manpower. The name of Quraysh therefore became more widely known. In later generations, forty tribes arose from the descendants of Quraysh, all of them settled in Mecca.

Chapter 2

Hashim ibn Abd Manaf and Mecca

Hashim was the son of Abd Manaf, a prominent leader of Quraysh. He was the great-grandfather of the Messenger of God and the father of Abd al-Muttalib. All the descendants of Abd al-Muttalib came to be known as Hashimites after him.

In Mecca, Hashim's clan had a separate enclosure known as Shi'b Abd al-Muttalib. A wall ran around it. Behind it stood Mount Abu Qubays. The enclosure extended into the mountain in a roughly circular form, while another hill lay about three hundred metres to the west. One of its gates opened toward that hill, and between the gate and the hill was an open space. A market known as Suq al-Layl stood there, and it belonged to Abd al-Muttalib.

The Messenger of God was born in a house within this same enclosure. It was the house of Abd al-Muttalib's son, Abdullah.

Before the Messenger of God proclaimed his prophethood, the Arab tribes descended from Ishmael, who had spread throughout Arabia, came to Mecca every year for the pilgrimage. At the same time, they conducted much of their annual buying and selling. These tribes respected Quraysh and did not harm their lives or property, because they knew that every year they would have to return to Mecca. The people of Mecca, in turn, treated these Arab tribes with hospitality.

After the Messenger of God proclaimed his prophethood, Mecca, where the Kaaba stood, became the central city of Islam. Mecca lies about eighty kilometres from the coast of the Red Sea.

Mecca is situated in a valley surrounded by small and large hills. It stands about five hundred feet above sea level. The hills around it are known collectively as the surrounding mountains. At the time of Abd al-Muttalib, the male population of the city was about 550. Women and slaves were not counted in population estimates at that time. Even if an equal number of women and slaves is added, the total would still not have exceeded about 1,500. Yet trade expanded so rapidly that by the time of the migration of the Messenger of God, the population had reached around three thousand.

The Economic Conditions of Mecca

Whenever people speak about the economy of Mecca, they often portray Arabia as utterly barren and desolate. I have travelled through the valley of Mecca as far as I could and have studied it closely. According to what I have seen, I do not believe that Mecca was always entirely uninhabitable. A city that possessed wells could hardly have been completely barren. The well of Zamzam itself must once have supplied drinkable water, and there must also have been trees. As the population increased, many of those trees would naturally have disappeared.

Historical evidence also suggests that, on one occasion, Hashim wanted the forests around Mecca to be cleared. Quraysh opposed him, saying that if the trees surrounding the Kaaba were cut down, divine punishment would descend. This indicates that there were once shrubs and trees around Mecca. Hashim nevertheless had the forest cleared despite their opposition.

Taif and the green mountainous region of al-Shafa also lie within reach of Mecca. I have seen both places myself. If one crosses the mountains directly rather than taking the modern road, Taif can be reached in a single day, from morning until evening. Al-Shafa lies only a little farther on. There, camels, horses, livestock, foodstuffs, and many other necessities were readily available.

When I first visited this region, I was astonished that our historians had so often overlooked al-Shafa when describing Mecca. We reached the area near the late afternoon. Clouds were moving over the settlement. The open fronts of shops revealed fruit and other goods inside. The coolness of the surrounding hills brought immediate relief. It was a large elevated settlement, where cold winds blew and where, in season, even snow could fall. It is difficult to imagine that a fertile and pleasant region so close to Mecca, filled with trees, birds, flowers, and fruit, would have had no effect on the life of the people of Mecca or that they would have remained unfamiliar with its produce.

The sea also lies not far to the west of Mecca. Mountains stand between Mecca and the coast, as they still do today. It is therefore inaccurate to imagine that the people of Mecca lived only among bare rocks and lifeless ground, without access to water or vegetation.

The valleys between the surrounding hills contain stretches of level ground where grass appears after rainfall. The people of Mecca could release their animals there to graze. There were pasturelands between the hills, as well as wells. Every tribe had its own grazing grounds and its own wells. At times, disputes over these resources led to conflict. Taif, al-Shafa, and the routes leading toward the Red Sea coast also provided Quraysh with avenues of trade and recreation.

Of all the prosperous settlements near Mecca, Taif was one of the most important. Goods and produce flowed from there into Mecca, where buying and selling took place. The tribes living in Taif maintained close relations with the people of Mecca, and the Banu Tha'qif in particular were closely connected with them. Abd al-Muttalib, and later Abu Talib, also had economic agreements with them and enjoyed considerable respect among them.

A well-known report concerning the people of Taif describes the Messenger of God being pelted with stones there. The author considers this report to have been fabricated and asks what purpose lay behind its invention. That question will be discussed later. For the moment, the present account continues with the economic life of Mecca.

There is little doubt that when Mecca had only a small population, its people depended heavily on sheep, goats, and camels. Bedouins from the surrounding region came there with their animals, while commercial caravans arriving from Syria and Yemen brought goods for sale. People from Mecca bought what they needed from these caravans and sold other goods in return. Those who came to Mecca for the pilgrimage and for visitation also contributed significantly to its economy.

Even before the birth of the Messenger of God, Hashim decided to establish trade on a much larger scale. After considerable effort, he gathered sufficient capital, acquired camels for commerce, and resolved to send trading caravans to Yemen, Abyssinia, Syria, and other lands.

The people of Mecca, as custodians of the Kaaba, already received certain benefits and therefore had little need to undertake difficult physical labour. Hashim, however, acted on his own initiative. He gave some of them money, took them with him, and directed them toward organised trade. They loaded camels with goods and set out with their caravans.

When Hashim returned from Syria, he brought substantial cash and merchandise from foreign lands. The people of Mecca gathered to see these goods. This trade improved the economy of the city considerably. Hashim then organised the business more systematically. He arranged for passing caravans to open markets, while Meccan merchants travelled in the direction of Yemen and Abyssinia and toward Gaza and other Syrian regions. These journeys exposed them to different countries, customs, and markets, broadened their outlook, and increased their wealth.

In this way, Mecca began to emerge as an international commercial centre. Hashim and his family became increasingly important in the organisation of caravans travelling between Yemen and Syria. The routes opened under his direction quickly became established.

During one year of severe famine in Mecca, Hashim wrote to Syria and had wheat and other food brought in. He distributed this food among the people. From then on, he continued to provide food for those who came to the Kaaba. His generosity became widely known, and people began to associate his name with the feeding of pilgrims.

This prosperity also encouraged other tribes and local Bedouins to participate in trade. Goods produced or gathered in the surrounding mountains, together with hides, livestock, metals, and other materials, were loaded onto camels and carried to the cities of Syria and Iraq.

Merchandise also passed through Mecca from East Africa and more distant eastern lands toward Syria. Such trade included animals, spices, hides, medicines, cloth, and slaves. The people of Mecca began to collect dues from this commerce. In this way, Mecca gradually became a small, self-governing commercial state. In return, the people obtained money, weapons, and grain, which they could sell to the tribes arriving from different parts of Arabia during the pilgrimage season.

Once the people of Mecca had become experienced in these affairs, Hashim reduced his own journeys. He travelled with a caravan only when a new commercial agreement had to be made or when he personally wished to participate in a major purchase.

On one occasion, he learned that merchants in Syria had treated a Meccan caravan harshly, refusing it suitable facilities and attempting to force its goods down in price. Hashim was deeply troubled. After considering the matter, he travelled to Syria and sought an audience with the Caesar. At the same time, he wrote to the Negus of Abyssinia.

Hashim was granted an audience because of his standing and influence. He spoke openly with the ruler and explained the losses suffered by Meccan caravans and the difficulties they encountered. After hearing him, the Caesar issued a firm written agreement concerning the caravans of Quraysh. It guaranteed the protection of their property and their security at stopping places, towns, and routes under his authority. Copies of this agreement were sent to the tribes and chiefs of Syria so that they would know the official policy toward the merchants of Mecca and would observe the terms of the agreement.

In the same way, Hashim secured arrangements that allowed Quraysh to trade more freely in Yemen and Abyssinia. These measures greatly assisted the uninterrupted buying and selling of Meccan caravans. During Hashim's lifetime, Quraysh became prosperous to the point that the old fear of hunger and insecurity largely disappeared.

As part of this commercial network, Hashim travelled several times to Yathrib, which later became known as Medina. He bought dates there and transported them toward

Abyssinia and Yemen, while also selling them in Mecca. During one such journey to Medina, he met Salma.

Salma bint Amr was a great-grandmother of the Messenger of God.

Hashim's Meeting with Salma bint Amr

On the road from Mecca to Medina was a settlement where, in later times, the railway station was established. The remains of its building can still be seen. When I first visited the place, it was still a substantial market, and many trees belonging to Jewish residents stood there.

Only a few of those trees now remain. From this point, one road led toward Jeddah, another toward Medina, a third toward Mecca, and a fourth toward Syria. A market was held there known as Suq al-Nabat. It stood at a crossroads where the routes to Syria, Mecca, Medina, and Jeddah separated.

On one of his commercial journeys, Hashim passed through this place and stopped at the market. People were gathered there buying and selling. He noticed an older but strikingly beautiful woman who stood out among everyone else in the market. She was actively engaged in trade. A turban was wrapped around her head and a heavy gold necklace hung around her neck. She sat at an elevated position in the market and directed her servants in buying and selling. Her voice carried clearly as she gave them instructions. Many strangers in the market were dealing with her.

Hashim was impressed not only by her appearance but by the firmness and confidence with which she conducted her business. He watched her for some time and then asked those around him who she was, what her name was, to which tribe she belonged, and whether she was married.

They told him that she was Salma bint Amr of the Banu Khazraj, from the Najjar branch of the tribe. She was free and was not married at that time.

She had previously been married to a man named Uhayhah ibn al-Julah and had two sons by him, Amr and Ma'bad. The marriage had not lasted. Their temperaments and dispositions were very different. Salma disliked his miserliness and harsh manner and divorced him. She then resolved not to marry again unless she found a man whom she respected and unless she retained the right to separate from him if the marriage became unbearable.

When Hashim learned this, he sent Salma a proposal of marriage. She recognised him as one of the most respected and honourable men among the Arabs of that time. Hashim

came before her, and they discussed the marriage directly. Salma accepted on the condition that she retain the right of divorce. Hashim accepted her condition.

Their marriage took place there in the same market. Hashim arranged a large feast in honour of the marriage. Traders present at the market were invited, and camels were slaughtered for food. Members of Banu Abd Manaf, Banu Makhzum, and other Quraysh clans were present, while members of Khazraj also attended from Salma's side.

After the marriage, Hashim remained with Salma there for about six months. During this period, she conceived the child who would later become Abd al-Muttalib.

Hashim then set out toward Syria with his companions. Before leaving, he told Salma that he would return to Mecca, but destiny decided otherwise. When the caravan reached Gaza, Hashim fell ill. The caravan remained there for a few days, hoping that he would recover, but his condition worsened. The other travellers eventually had to continue on their way.

Hashim died in Gaza. The members of the caravan buried him there and, on their return to Mecca, informed the people of his death. Salma was unable to return with him.

In about 480 CE, Abd al-Muttalib was born in Medina. His mother named him Shaybah al-Hamd, and he was raised in Medina.

Chapter 3

Abd al-Muttalib and Medina

It is appropriate here to say something about the childhood of Abd al-Muttalib.

Before Hashim died, he entrusted his brother Muttalib with his affairs. Some time after Hashim's death, a caravan belonging to Quraysh passed near Medina. The travellers saw a young boy at play who drew their attention. He was small in stature, dark-complexioned, and clearly bore the marks of intelligence and courage. One of the men said that the boy strongly resembled Hashim. The others looked at him closely and agreed.

When the caravan moved on toward Mecca, the travellers mentioned the matter to Muttalib. They told him that they had seen a boy near Medina whose face greatly resembled that of his late brother Hashim. They also told him that the boy was known as Shaybah and that he was the son of Salma bint Amr, the woman whom Hashim had married in Medina.

Muttalib immediately became concerned. If the boy was truly Hashim's son, then he was his own nephew and belonged among his father's people in Mecca. He therefore travelled to Medina to investigate the matter for himself.

When Muttalib reached Medina, he asked for Salma and was shown where she lived. He then saw the boy. The resemblance left little room for doubt. Muttalib spoke to him, asked his name, and learned that he was indeed Shaybah, son of Hashim. He embraced him warmly and introduced himself as the boy's uncle.

He then went to Salma and asked permission to take Shaybah with him to Mecca. Salma refused. She said that the boy was still young, that he was accustomed to living with his mother, and that there was no reason to separate him from her. Muttalib continued to press the matter, explaining that Shaybah belonged to a family of honour and leadership in Mecca and that his father's people had rights over him.

Salma still hesitated. She feared that if she allowed the boy to leave, she might never see him again. Muttalib therefore tried another approach. He told her that the boy would have a better future among his father's family, that his lineage would be recognised there, and that he would inherit the standing that belonged to the house of Hashim.

After lengthy discussion, Salma agreed on the condition that Shaybah himself should be willing to go. Muttalib then spoke to the boy. Shaybah was intrigued by the thought of seeing Mecca and his father's people, and he agreed to travel with his uncle.

Muttalib placed him behind himself on his camel and set out for Mecca.

When they entered the city, the people saw Muttalib riding with a young boy seated behind him. Because the boy was dusty from travel and because no one immediately knew who he was, some people assumed that Muttalib had bought a slave. They therefore began calling him "Abd al-Muttalib," meaning "the slave of Muttalib."

Muttalib objected and told them that the boy was no slave. "He is my nephew," he said, "the son of my brother Hashim." Yet the name had already caught on, and Shaybah thereafter became widely known as Abd al-Muttalib.

He was about seven or eight years old when he came to Mecca.

Abd al-Muttalib's Early Years

Abd al-Muttalib grew up in Mecca among the Banu Hashim and the wider Quraysh. He was intelligent, observant, and strong-minded. He also possessed a natural dignity that gradually made him noticeable among his relatives.

Not long after his arrival, a dispute arose concerning the inheritance and property of his father Hashim. Some of Hashim's property had remained in the hands of other relatives, and Abd al-Muttalib believed that his rightful share was being withheld.

At first he was too young to do anything about it. As he grew older, however, he began asking questions. He learned which lands, possessions, and responsibilities had belonged to his father and which members of the family now controlled them.

His uncle Muttalib supported him, but Muttalib did not live long. After Muttalib's death, the situation became more difficult. Abd al-Muttalib found himself facing men older and more powerful than he was, some of whom were unwilling to surrender property they had already taken into their possession.

Among those with whom he came into conflict was Nawfal ibn Abd Manaf, another of Hashim's brothers. Nawfal had taken possession of property that Abd al-Muttalib regarded as his own inheritance. Abd al-Muttalib demanded its return, but Nawfal refused.

Abd al-Muttalib then sought support from his relatives in Mecca, but few were prepared to involve themselves. He realised that he could not rely entirely on the local branches of Quraysh.

He therefore remembered his mother's people in Medina, the Banu Najjar of Khazraj.

He wrote to them, explaining that he was the son of their daughter Salma and that he was being wronged in Mecca. He asked them to come to his aid.

The appeal had an immediate effect.

A group of his maternal relatives, armed and ready, travelled from Medina to Mecca. They entered the city openly and announced that they had come to defend the rights of their sister's son. Their arrival changed the situation at once. Nawfal saw that Abd al-Muttalib now had strong backing and that the dispute might lead to bloodshed if he continued to resist.

He therefore returned the disputed property.

This episode strengthened Abd al-Muttalib's position considerably. People in Mecca now understood that, although he had grown up away from his father's family, he was not without powerful supporters.

From that time onward, his standing among Quraysh continued to rise.

Abd al-Muttalib's Leadership and Trade

Abd al-Muttalib inherited not merely a family name but also the commercial responsibilities associated with the house of Hashim.

By this period, Quraysh had developed extensive trade connections. Caravans travelled north toward Syria and south toward Yemen, while commercial relations also linked Mecca with Abyssinia and other regions. The leading families of Quraysh maintained agreements that allowed their caravans to pass safely through tribal territories.

Abd al-Muttalib took an active role in these affairs.

On one occasion, a commercial disagreement arose between Quraysh and certain tribes. Abd al-Muttalib was sent to settle the matter. He spoke with the opposing chiefs, negotiated terms, and succeeded in restoring the arrangements under which the caravans could continue travelling in safety.

His reputation for judgment and diplomacy increased.

He was also associated with the arrangements for feeding and supplying pilgrims who came to Mecca. The custodianship of the Kaaba brought honour, but it also imposed responsibilities. Pilgrims had to be provided with water, food, and protection, and the leading families of Quraysh competed for the distinction of serving them.

Abd al-Muttalib became one of the most prominent men in this system.

A Dispute with Harb ibn Umayyah

As Abd al-Muttalib's prestige increased, rivalry arose between him and Harb ibn Umayyah.

Harb was a wealthy and influential man of the Banu Umayyah. His family was active in trade and enjoyed considerable standing among Quraysh. Abd al-Muttalib, however, had inherited the prestige of Hashim and increasingly occupied the foremost position in Mecca.

The two men eventually entered into a dispute over which of them possessed greater honour and leadership.

They agreed to appoint an arbitrator.

The arbitrator heard both sides and decided in favour of Abd al-Muttalib. According to the account preserved here, Harb was required to hand over one hundred camels and a number of slaves as the agreed stake in the arbitration.

The judgment was an important public recognition of Abd al-Muttalib's superiority in status.

The rivalry, however, did not disappear. It became part of the long competition between the houses of Hashim and Umayyah, a rivalry that would continue into later generations.

Success at Taif

The people of Mecca were not confined to trade within the city. They sought agricultural land and commercial interests in nearby regions, especially Taif, whose climate was cooler and whose soil was more fertile.

Abd al-Muttalib acquired property there.

Taif was known for gardens, orchards, grapes, and other produce. Wealthy Meccan families invested in land there because agriculture provided a stable source of income in addition to caravan trade.

Abd al-Muttalib's interests in Taif prospered, and this added further to his wealth.

The author notes that this prosperity should be remembered whenever Mecca is described as though its leading men possessed no economic resources beyond the pilgrimage. The commercial and agricultural connections of Quraysh extended into the surrounding regions and formed a substantial part of their material life.

The Return of Zamzam

One of the most famous events associated with Abd al-Muttalib was the rediscovery of the well of Zamzam.

The well had been lost for a long period. Its exact location had been forgotten, and people drew their water from other wells around Mecca.

According to the well-known account, Abd al-Muttalib repeatedly saw a dream in which he was told to dig at a particular place near the Kaaba.

At first the instructions were unclear. The dream came again, and then again, each time with greater precision. Finally he was told that he was to dig for Zamzam.

Abd al-Muttalib asked where Zamzam was.

He was given signs by which to recognise the place.

The next morning he went to the area indicated in the dream. He began to search for the exact spot. After identifying it, he took tools and started digging.

At that time he had only one son, Harith, to assist him.

The other men of Quraysh watched but did not help. Some even mocked him. Digging into the hard ground beside the Kaaba was exhausting work, and no one knew whether the effort would produce anything.

Abd al-Muttalib continued.

After persistent digging, he came upon the remains of the old well. As the excavation deepened, water appeared.

The discovery caused great excitement throughout Mecca.

The Quraysh immediately came forward and claimed a share in the well. They argued that Zamzam belonged to Ishmael and therefore to all his descendants, not to Abd al-Muttalib alone.

Abd al-Muttalib rejected their claim. He said that he had been guided to the well and that he and his son had undertaken the labour of digging it while the others had refused to assist.

The disagreement became serious.

At length both sides agreed to submit the matter to an arbitrator. They were told of a priestess or soothsayer belonging to the tribe of Sa'd who lived in the direction of Syria, and they decided to travel to her for judgment.

A group from Abd al-Muttalib's side and a group from the other clans of Quraysh set out together.

During the journey, their water ran out.

They were in a desolate region. The heat was severe, and there was no settlement nearby from which they could obtain help. Their animals were exhausted, and the travellers feared that they would die of thirst.

Each group tried to preserve what little water remained for itself.

Soon even that was gone.

The men began to lose hope.

Abd al-Muttalib then told his companions that they should not simply sit and wait for death. He suggested that each man dig a grave for himself while he still had the strength. Then, if one died, the others could bury him. In this way only the last survivor would remain unburied.

They accepted the grim proposal and began preparing their graves.

After some time, however, Abd al-Muttalib reconsidered. He said that to remain there passively was cowardice. They should continue searching. Perhaps God would provide a way out.

They mounted their camels again.

As Abd al-Muttalib's camel rose, its foot struck the ground and water appeared from beneath it.

The travellers cried out in relief. They drank, filled their containers, and gave water to their animals.

The other Quraysh who had been travelling with them saw what had happened and said to Abd al-Muttalib that this was itself a judgment between them. The One who had

provided water for him in the wilderness had also granted him the right to Zamzam. They no longer needed to continue to the arbitrator.

They returned to Mecca and recognised Abd al-Muttalib's claim over the well.

From then on, Zamzam became one of the chief sources of water for pilgrims and for the people of Mecca.

The Meaning of the Dream

The author observes that the account of the rediscovery of Zamzam is closely connected with dreams and asks how such reports should be understood.

Quraysh had long possessed traditions about the old well. Its existence was known even though its exact location had been forgotten. It is therefore possible, the author argues, that Abd al-Muttalib had heard descriptions of its former position and that these memories returned to him in sleep in the form of repeated dreams.

There is no need, in this view, to regard every detail of the story as miraculous in a literal sense. A person may think deeply about a matter during the day and then see it in a dream at night. The mind can preserve impressions and clues that later reappear in symbolic form.

What is important is that Abd al-Muttalib acted with determination. He searched where he believed the well to be, persevered despite ridicule, and succeeded in bringing Zamzam back into use.

The Treasure of Zamzam

When the old well was excavated, objects were also found within it.

According to the reports, these included swords, armour, and two golden gazelles. The items were said to have been deposited there in earlier times, perhaps by the Jurhum when they were forced to leave Mecca.

Abd al-Muttalib and Quraysh disputed over these objects as well.

To settle the matter, they used a customary form of drawing lots. Separate arrows were assigned to the Kaaba, to Abd al-Muttalib, and to Quraysh. The lots were then drawn.

The golden gazelles fell to the Kaaba, the swords and armour to Abd al-Muttalib, and nothing to Quraysh.

Abd al-Muttalib used the swords to strengthen the door of the Kaaba and dedicated the golden gazelles to the sanctuary.

Conflict with Umayyah

As Abd al-Muttalib's position became stronger, tension with the Umayyad branch of Quraysh continued.

The rivalry was not merely personal. It reflected competition between two houses for prestige, leadership, trade, and influence in Mecca.

A dispute arose involving Abd al-Muttalib and Umayyah ibn Abd Shams. They agreed to arbitration, and once again the judgment went in Abd al-Muttalib's favour.

The arbitrator ruled that Umayyah should leave Mecca for a period of ten years.

Umayyah therefore went to Syria and remained there until the term had passed.

The incident further strengthened the status of the Banu Hashim.

Abd al-Muttalib's Vow

The rediscovery of Zamzam had been difficult. At the time, Abd al-Muttalib had only one son, Harith, to assist and defend him. Surrounded by the larger clans of Quraysh, he felt his weakness keenly.

He therefore made a vow.

If God granted him ten sons who grew to maturity and were able to stand beside him, he would sacrifice one of them.

In time, the number of his sons reached ten.

When they had grown into young men, Abd al-Muttalib remembered his vow and told them about it.

He said that he had made a pledge to God and must now fulfil it.

His sons did not oppose him. They told him to do what he had vowed.

Abd al-Muttalib then took them to the place where lots were drawn and had each son's name written on an arrow.

The lot was cast.

It fell upon Abdullah.

Abdullah was one of the youngest of his sons and was especially dear to him.

Abd al-Muttalib took a knife and led Abdullah toward the place of sacrifice.

The people of Quraysh intervened.

They told Abd al-Muttalib not to carry out the sacrifice until every possible alternative had been explored. If he killed his own son in fulfilment of such a vow, they feared that the act might become a precedent and other fathers might begin doing the same.

They advised him to consult a diviner.

Abd al-Muttalib agreed.

The diviner asked what the recognised blood-money for a human life was among them.

They replied that it was ten camels.

She instructed them to place Abdullah on one side and ten camels on the other and draw lots. If the lot fell upon Abdullah, another ten camels were to be added. They were to continue increasing the number until the lot finally fell upon the camels.

They followed her instructions.

The lot fell on Abdullah when there were ten camels, then again when there were twenty, thirty, forty, and so on.

Each time ten more camels were added.

Only when the number reached one hundred did the lot fall upon the camels.

Abd al-Muttalib was not yet satisfied. He repeated the drawing several times to be certain.

Each time, the lot fell upon the one hundred camels.

He then accepted the result. The camels were slaughtered and Abdullah's life was spared.

The event became famous, and the compensation of one hundred camels later came to be regarded as the blood-money for a life.

Abdullah's Marriage

Once Abdullah's life had been spared, Abd al-Muttalib began thinking about his marriage.

Abdullah was a handsome young man and, because of the events surrounding the vow, had attracted considerable attention.

Abd al-Muttalib sought a suitable wife for him and chose Aminah bint Wahb of the Banu Zuhrah.

Aminah belonged to a respected family of Quraysh. Her father, Wahb ibn Abd Manaf ibn Zuhrah, was regarded as one of the leading men of his clan.

Abd al-Muttalib went with Abdullah to propose the marriage.

The proposal was accepted, and Abdullah married Aminah.

On the same occasion, Abd al-Muttalib himself married Halah bint Uhayb, a woman from the same wider family.

Thus father and son were married at about the same time.

From the marriage of Abd al-Muttalib and Halah was born Hamzah, who would later become the celebrated uncle of the Messenger of God.

From the marriage of Abdullah and Aminah would be born Muhammad, the Messenger of God.

According to the author, some later narrations greatly embellished the circumstances of Abdullah's marriage, describing extraordinary light or signs upon his face and women who supposedly sought him because they recognised the coming prophethood in him. Such stories, the author argues, are later additions and should not be treated as reliable history.

What can be said with confidence is simpler: Abdullah was a young man of distinguished lineage, his father arranged his marriage with Aminah bint Wahb, and the marriage took place in accordance with the customs of Quraysh.

Chapter 4

The Shape, Appearance, and Construction of the Kaaba

When I went to Mecca for Hajj and saw the Kaaba for the first time, I too imagined, as many people do, that its walls must be immensely thick and that its foundations must go very deep into the ground. The Kaaba stands in a place that has endured for centuries, and from a distance one naturally assumes that it must be built like a massive stone fortress. But when I saw it closely, my impression changed. The House of God was quite different from what I had imagined.

After returning, I tried to learn the measurements of its walls and structure. In 1995 it was not easy to take exact measurements, especially in the crowded area around the Kaaba, but the dimensions can be given approximately. From the Black Stone to the Iraqi corner the wall is about 38 feet 4 inches; from the Iraqi corner to the Syrian corner, about 32 feet 6 inches; from the Syrian corner to the Yemeni corner, about 39 feet 6 inches; and from the Yemeni corner back to the Black Stone, about 33 feet 5 inches.

The walls are therefore not extraordinarily long. What gives the building its imposing appearance is its height. Its present height is much greater than it was in earlier times. It is said that the old Kaaba was no more than about 23 feet high, roughly the height of a four-storey ordinary house.

In the age of Abd al-Muttalib, the walls of the Kaaba were not built in the form in which we see them today. The building was then only about six or seven feet high, and its roof was supported on wooden pillars. Inside were four posts on which lamps were hung. Oil was poured into these lamps and they were kept burning. The walls were made of stone, but they were low and simple. The doorway on the eastern side stood only a short distance above the ground so that rainwater could flow inside. Along the interior walls there were niches in which valuables and offerings were stored.

At that time there were also idols in and around the Kaaba. Some were of stone and some of wood. The best known among them was Hubal. There were other idols as well, and people came from different tribes to worship them. Paintings and other objects were also kept inside. The interior was not the empty space familiar to later generations.

The roof was made from timber. In those days good timber did not come easily to Mecca, so wood brought from the coast or recovered from damaged ships was highly prized. The

roofing material was laid across the walls, then covered in such a way as to protect the interior from heat and rain.

The Black Stone was fixed in one corner. It was not a single large stone in the form in which most people imagine it. Even in early times it consisted of pieces held together. Its colour had also changed over the centuries. Tradition speaks of it as originally lighter in colour, but constant touching, smoke, dust, weathering, and later damage altered its appearance.

Near the Kaaba stood the place known as the Hijr, or Hatim. Part of the area now lying outside the present wall was regarded as belonging to the original structure. The wall that enclosed the Hijr was low and curved. Pilgrims passed around it during circumambulation.

The Kaaba was therefore a comparatively small building surrounded by open ground. Around it stood the houses of Quraysh. These houses were not pressed immediately against the sanctuary. There was space between the Kaaba and the dwellings, and the various clans occupied their own quarters around the sacred precinct.

Because Mecca lies in a valley, rainwater could become dangerous. Heavy rain came down from the surrounding hills and rushed toward the sanctuary. On one occasion a severe flood damaged the Kaaba. Water entered the building, weakened the walls, and threatened to bring them down. The people of Quraysh realised that the House could no longer be left as it was.

Another incident added to the danger. A woman entered the Kaaba one day to burn incense. A spark from the fire caught the covering or wooden structure, and flames spread. The Kaaba was badly damaged. Its roof and walls were left in a condition in which reconstruction became unavoidable.

Quraysh now had to decide whether to demolish the old structure and rebuild it. They were frightened. No one wished to be the first to strike the sacred building with a tool, lest some punishment descend upon him. At last one of their elders took courage, removed a stone, and waited to see what would happen. When no calamity followed, the others joined him.

They decided that only lawful and clean earnings would be used in rebuilding the Kaaba. Money acquired through prostitution, usury, theft, injustice, or other forms of wrongdoing was not to be accepted. Their resources, however, were limited. When the funds ran short, they reduced the dimensions of the building and left part of the original foundation outside the new walls. This is the area later enclosed within the Hijr.

At about this time a ship had been wrecked on the Red Sea coast. Quraysh purchased timber from it and brought a skilled carpenter to Mecca. The wood was used for the roof and other parts of the new building. The walls were raised course by course with stone and timber laid between sections for strength.

When the rebuilding reached the level at which the Black Stone had to be placed, a serious dispute arose. Every clan wanted the honour of putting the Stone back into its position. The quarrel became so intense that bloodshed seemed possible. Some men even pledged themselves to fight rather than surrender the privilege.

At last they agreed that the next person to enter the sanctuary should arbitrate between them.

The first man to appear was Muhammad ibn Abdullah, who had not yet announced his prophethood. They were pleased when they saw him, for he was already known among them as trustworthy.

He asked for a cloth. The Black Stone was placed in the middle of it, and representatives of the rival clans were told to take hold of the edges together. They lifted it jointly. Muhammad then took the Stone with his own hands and set it into its place.

In this way a dispute that might have led to bloodshed was resolved.

The reconstructed Kaaba was higher than before and more secure. Its door was raised above ground level, so that entry could be controlled. The roof was made stronger, and the building assumed a form much closer to that known in later times.

The reconstruction is generally placed about five years before Muhammad's call to prophethood, when he was around thirty-five years old.

The Elephant and the Reality of Abraha

Before discussing the later events in the life of Abd al-Muttalib, it is necessary to consider the well-known story of the Elephant.

The common account says that Abraha, the ruler of Yemen on behalf of Abyssinia, built a magnificent church in Sana'a. He wished to divert the pilgrimage of the Arabs away from the Kaaba and toward his new church. An Arab, angered by this intention, entered the church and defiled it. Abraha then swore to destroy the Kaaba. He marched toward Mecca with a great army that included elephants.

According to the traditional story, the tribes of Arabia attempted to resist him but were defeated. When the army reached the vicinity of Mecca, some of the livestock belonging to Quraysh was seized, including camels belonging to Abd al-Muttalib.

Abraha then sent a messenger to summon the leading man of Mecca. Abd al-Muttalib went to meet him. Abraha was impressed by his appearance and dignity and received him with honour.

Abraha expected Abd al-Muttalib to plead for the Kaaba, but Abd al-Muttalib asked only that his camels be returned.

Abraha is said to have replied in surprise, "I admired you when I saw you, but now my respect for you has diminished. I have come to destroy the House that is the centre of your religion and the honour of your people, yet you speak only of your camels."

Abd al-Muttalib answered, "I am the owner of the camels. The House has an Owner who will protect it."

The camels were returned. Abd al-Muttalib went back to Mecca, advised the people to leave the city, and withdrew with them toward the hills.

The traditional account continues by saying that when Abraha ordered the army to advance, the elephant refused to move toward the Kaaba. If turned in another direction, it would walk, but when turned toward Mecca it sat down. Then flocks of birds appeared from the direction of the sea, each carrying small stones. They dropped the stones upon the army, which was destroyed. Abraha himself was badly injured and returned toward Yemen, where he later died.

This event is ordinarily connected with the Qur'anic passage concerning the Companions of the Elephant.

The author, however, does not accept every detail of the popular story as literal history. The narrative, in his view, contains later embellishments and raises a number of historical difficulties.

If Abraha had truly set out to destroy the Kaaba because one Arab had defiled his church, why would he have treated Abd al-Muttalib with such courtesy? Why return his camels and then proceed to destroy the sanctuary whose custodian he was? If an enormous army with elephants had advanced through Arabia, its movements should have left clearer traces in contemporary records.

The political situation of Yemen and Abyssinia must also be considered. Abraha was not an independent emperor free to undertake any campaign he wished. He ruled within a wider political order and had commercial and strategic interests to protect. A major

expedition toward Mecca would have required resources, routes, and objectives greater than the simple motive usually given in popular accounts.

The number of elephants is another difficulty. Elephants were not ordinary animals in Arabia, and transporting them across the long and difficult route into the Hijaz would itself have been a major undertaking. Later narrators differ over how many there were, which shows that the details were not securely preserved.

The story of the birds and stones has likewise been expanded in later retellings. The Qur'anic passage itself is brief. It speaks of the Companions of the Elephant, of birds in flocks, and of stones of baked clay, but the elaborate descriptions found in later narratives should not automatically be treated as part of the earliest historical account.

The essential point, according to the author, is that a hostile force came toward Mecca and was destroyed before it could achieve its purpose. The people of Mecca understood this as divine protection of the Kaaba. The later storytelling surrounding the event should be distinguished from that central fact.

The incident greatly increased the prestige of Quraysh. The Arabs already respected the custodians of the Kaaba, but after the failure of the invading army the sanctity of Mecca appeared even more firmly established. Abd al-Muttalib's standing also rose. He had remained calm during the crisis, had not submitted to the invader, and had trusted that the sanctuary would be protected.

The Death of Abdullah

Some time after his marriage to Aminah bint Wahb, Abdullah set out with a trading caravan.

He was still a young man. On the return journey he became ill near Medina. Because his mother's relatives, the Banu Najjar, lived there, he remained with them while the caravan continued to Mecca.

When the caravan reached Mecca, Abd al-Muttalib asked where his son was. He was told that Abdullah had fallen ill in Medina and had stayed behind.

Abd al-Muttalib immediately sent one of his sons to inquire about him. By the time the messenger reached Medina, Abdullah had died.

The news was brought back to Mecca.

Abd al-Muttalib was deeply grieved. Abdullah had been especially dear to him, and his death came at a time when Aminah was expecting a child. The loss therefore fell not only

upon a father who had lost his son but upon a young wife whose child would be born without a father.

Abdullah was buried in Medina among the relatives of his mother's family.

The reports differ over his exact age, but he was still a young man. His estate was modest. It included a few camels or goats and a slave-woman named Umm Ayman, who would later remain connected with the household of his son.

Muhammad was therefore born after the death of his father.

Reaching Aminah's Grave

The Messenger of God knew where his mother had been buried. Later in life, when he passed through that region, he visited her grave.

Aminah had taken the young Muhammad from Mecca to Medina to visit his maternal relatives and to show him the place where his father had died and been buried. Umm Ayman accompanied them.

They remained in Medina for some time. On the return journey, Aminah became ill at a place called Abwa, between Medina and Mecca.

Her condition worsened, and she died there.

Muhammad was still a child.

Umm Ayman brought him back to Mecca and delivered him to Abd al-Muttalib.

The author draws attention to the loneliness of the child at this stage of his life. His father had died before his birth, and now his mother had also died. He had travelled with her toward Medina and returned without her. The memory of that journey and of her grave remained with him.

Many years later, when the Messenger of God passed through Abwa, he stopped at the grave of his mother. He sat there and wept. Those around him also wept.

He asked permission to pray for her forgiveness, but according to the report, permission was not granted. He was, however, permitted to visit her grave.

The author regards the emotional force of the episode as clear: a son, now advanced in years and carrying the responsibilities of prophethood, stood again at the grave of the mother he had lost in childhood.

The Majesty and Death of Abd al-Muttalib

It is difficult to overstate the standing Abd al-Muttalib possessed among Quraysh. His father and grandfather had both been leaders, and through his mother he was connected with the Khazraj of Medina. He had inherited wealth, dignity, and political influence, and his natural bearing increased the respect people showed him.

He was a tall, handsome, imposing man. When he sat near the Kaaba, a special carpet was spread for him. His sons sat around it, but none would sit upon the carpet itself out of respect for him.

The young Muhammad, however, would sometimes come and sit directly on his grandfather's carpet.

His uncles tried to move him away, but Abd al-Muttalib stopped them. "Leave my son," he would say. "By God, there is something remarkable about him."

He would draw the boy close, seat him beside himself, and show him affection.

Abd al-Muttalib understood that Muhammad had lost both father and mother. He therefore took special care of him and did not allow him to feel abandoned in the household.

On one occasion, Muhammad was missing. Abd al-Muttalib became extremely anxious and sent people in different directions to search for him. When the child was finally found and brought back, Abd al-Muttalib embraced him and expressed how deeply his disappearance had frightened him.

The affection between grandfather and grandson was therefore strong.

Abd al-Muttalib was also respected beyond his own family. Men of Quraysh consulted him in serious matters. Travellers, merchants, and tribal chiefs recognised his authority. His position was not merely ceremonial; he was one of the central figures through whom Meccan affairs were conducted.

Yet he was now an old man.

When Muhammad was about eight years old, Abd al-Muttalib's health declined. Realising that death was near, he had to decide who would care for the child after him.

Among his sons, Abu Talib was the full brother of Abdullah, Muhammad's father. For this reason, and because of his affection and character, Abd al-Muttalib entrusted Muhammad to Abu Talib.

He instructed Abu Talib to protect the boy, care for him, and never neglect him.

Abu Talib accepted the responsibility.

Abd al-Muttalib died in 579 CE, corresponding to the Year of the Elephant according to the chronology followed in this book. He was about ninety-nine years old.

His death was deeply mourned in Mecca. The people of Quraysh regarded him as one of their greatest leaders, and his household felt the loss intensely.

The young Muhammad had now lost his father before birth, his mother in early childhood, and his grandfather only a short time later.

From that point onward, his care passed to Abu Talib.

Chapter 5

Abu Talib's Economic Position and Leadership

Abu Talib was five or six years older than his brother Abdullah. Their mother was Fatimah bint Amr, so Abdullah and Abu Talib were full brothers, sharing both father and mother. Since the Messenger of God was placed in Abu Talib's care, the responsibilities and standing associated with his family also came to rest with him, and the leadership of Mecca likewise passed into his hands.

When the leadership of Mecca came to Abu Talib, the offices and privileges attached to it also became his. These were the distinctions and responsibilities that had been inherited generation after generation from Ishmael and Qusayy down through Hashim and Abd al-Muttalib. They included Zamzam, properties connected with the sanctuary, other estates, houses, gardens, and female servants. These possessions formed part of an inherited estate whose principal heir in Mecca was the man who held the city's leadership. The holdings at Taif, together with their dependent properties and servants, were likewise included among the assets that eventually came into Abu Talib's possession.

Suq al-Layl

What was Suq al-Layl, the market mentioned in connection with Taif and Abu Talib, and what was discussed there?

Abd al-Muttalib himself provides some clarification. After the death of his uncle Muttalib, when he encountered strong opposition and many difficulties, one of the reforms he introduced was the establishment of a central market called Suq al-Layl. It became an organised marketplace from which the broader commercial activity of Mecca developed.

Previously, when caravans arrived in Mecca for buying and selling, they would be lodged in an open field. Buyers would come there, but business could not continue at all times. Rain or severe weather spoiled goods, and theft was also a danger. Merchants therefore needed a protected place for their merchandise.

A market was consequently established in which goods could be bought and sold more securely and where poor people could also purchase what they needed. Abd al-Muttalib organised such a market at a central location in Mecca. It consisted of a series of shops in one row, with a road between them. A roof was built over the road so that people would be protected from the sun and rain. Merchants could display their wares in the shops, while a fee was collected from those doing business there.

This market was part of Abd al-Muttalib's estate. After him it passed to Abu Talib, and from him it later came into the possession of the Messenger of God.

At this point, I should correct a common mistake. Our Muslim brothers from Banu Umayyah spread many reports against the Ahl al-Bayt when they came to control the writing of history. Among these reports are repeated attempts to portray Abu Talib, peace be upon him, as a poor man. These claims are historically weak and do not accord with the evidence.

Even a brief examination shows that a man who possessed inherited property, commercial interests, access to the market, and the leadership of Mecca could not reasonably be described as destitute. Such reports appear to have been created later in order to diminish his standing.

Abu Talib's marriage and household also show that he was not a man without means. His wife was Fatimah bint Asad, from a respected family, and his sons and daughters were raised within a household that held recognised status among Quraysh.

When we look at the children of Abu Talib, we find that he had four sons. Talib was the eldest, then Aqil, then Ja'far, and then Ali. His sons were separated from one another by about ten years in age: Talib was about ten years older than Aqil, Aqil about ten years older than Ja'far, and Ja'far about ten years older than Ali.

This point is important because some later writers created an exaggerated picture of Abu Talib's supposed poverty. They claimed that when the Messenger of God grew older, he and Abbas divided Abu Talib's children between themselves because Abu Talib was unable to support them. According to that story, one child was taken by Abbas and another by the Messenger of God.

But the account does not withstand scrutiny. At the time in question, two of Abu Talib's sons were already mature young men and were themselves engaged in trade. How, then, could the household be described as one in which the children had to be distributed because their father could not feed them?

If the size of the family is considered, the weakness of the report becomes even clearer. One must ask how much food such a household actually required, what income came from trade, and what protection from economic hardship was provided by the family's inherited resources.

Even today it is difficult to understand how someone who owns property and has access to commercial income can simply be described as destitute. The idea that Abu Talib's entire household depended on others merely for food is therefore not convincing.

The truth is that when the Messenger of God was still a child, Abu Talib cared for him with deep affection. In return, the Prophet remained closely attached to him throughout his life. This bond should not be confused with later stories intended to present Abu Talib as helpless or impoverished.

When the Messenger of God reached about fifteen years of age, his cousin Ali was not yet born. Talib, however, was already around thirty, while Aqil and Ja'far were also old enough to take part in family affairs and commercial work. It is therefore unreasonable to suppose that the entire household had become dependent on others for its daily bread.

Besides Suq al-Layl and the inherited properties of Taif, Abu Talib had other economic resources and trading connections. I wish to make one point clear: in those days, people did not rely only on liquid cash. Ownership of land, orchards, houses, servants, market rights, and commercial arrangements all formed part of a man's wealth.

Thus, even if hard times occasionally came—as they did to every household in Mecca—this does not mean that Abu Talib was poor in the sense later writers suggested. To portray temporary difficulty as permanent destitution is historically misleading.

The accusation seems to have arisen largely because later polemical writers wanted to lessen Abu Talib's standing. The same tendency appears in other matters connected with him. Yet the record of his property, his position, his family, and his public authority presents a very different picture.

The Messenger of God's own later treatment of Abu Talib's family also confirms the closeness between them. The Prophet gave particular care to the sons of Abu Talib, and his affection for Ali, Ja'far, and the others grew out of longstanding family ties.

Abu Talib's position, therefore, should be understood in the light of his inherited leadership, his commercial interests, his property, and his family connections. He was not merely the guardian of the young Muhammad; he was also one of the principal men of Mecca and the inheritor of the authority of the house of Hashim.

Chapter 6

My Arrival in Mecca

I first entered Mecca in November 1993, when I was twenty-one years old. At that time the city was still small, and there were many barbers. In India and Pakistan, whoever managed to obtain a visa would become a *Haji*; indeed, many of those pilgrims returned every year in the guise of Hajj. In a month and a half they would earn enough to support themselves for the year, then go back to Pakistan and run their businesses under the title *al-Haj*. The following year they would return for Hajj again. I saw dozens of such barbers who, with a single stroke, seemed capable of removing both a pilgrim's hair and his ear.

I had entered on an Umrah visa. In fact, I was supposed to go first to a goldsmith friend in Jeddah and work with him as a jeweller. I certainly intended to work, but my real purpose was to visit the sacred places of the Hijaz.

When I landed in Jeddah, it was night. The city was unfamiliar. I had no ihram with me, though I knew about Umrah. I decided that I would first go into Jeddah and spend the night with my goldsmith friend. The next day I would obtain an ihram, learn what I needed to know about Umrah, put it on, and leave for Mecca. I would perform Umrah first, then go to Medina, and only afterward return to Jeddah and sit down to work in his shop.

For me, Mecca was no less than one of those legendary worlds that a person dreams of seeing and wandering through, yet never expects the dream to become reality. Leaving home for Hajj was not merely a journey through unfamiliar cities; it was a journey back into centuries that seemed to carry me fourteen hundred years into the past.

At immigration, however, an Arab officer took me aside, seized my passport, and said, "Go straight from here to Mecca by taxi. You cannot enter Jeddah. You will receive your passport in Mecca."

The passports of several other passengers travelling with me were also in their custody. I had no objection to going to Mecca; that was the very longing that had brought me here. But in those days I was, in my own understanding, a strictly observant Muslim. I believed that I could not enter the Haram without ihram, and I had none with me. My mind began racing. Could I buy an ihram at the airport? Was there somewhere I could put it on before entering the sacred precinct?

I also knew that if I went into Saudi Arabia without my passport I would be helpless. Without it, movement from place to place was difficult, and finding work would be out of the question.

At last, a man noticed my distress and asked what was wrong. I told him my story. He smiled and said, “We are people of the qiblah, and these are Arabs; we understand how such matters work. Take fifty riyals from your pocket, put them into the officer’s fist, and take back your passport.”

I did exactly as he said. The effect was immediate. I received my passport.

Believe me, that was my first “act of worship” on the soil of the Hijaz.

When the door opened afterward, I stepped outside and respectfully parted from the friend who had helped me. I shared a taxi with four other men. My share of the fare came to ten riyals, and the taxi set off.

As the car moved toward Mecca, history seemed to reach out a finger and draw me inside itself. I no longer felt that I was simply travelling through the present. It seemed as though I were moving through many ages at once. Every hill and rocky rise awakened some image in my mind, and my imagination surrounded the landscape with thoughts of the Messenger of God and Abu Talib, peace be upon him.

At last the taxi stopped at a place called Bab al-Umrah. It was, I believe, on the southern side of the Kaaba. It was neither Hajj season nor Ramadan, so there was hardly any crowd. Before me was a somewhat narrow open space with a great deal of marble. The ground nearby was paved with asphalt, and beyond it stood the entrance to the Haram.

There was scarcely anyone between me and the entrance. The stillness and the unfamiliarity of the scene overwhelmed me. Clean stone steps rose nearby toward Safa. Between the surrounding buildings and the gate of the Haram was an open area of the kind that leaves a newcomer uncertain where to turn.

I stood there for a while, looking around. Then I opened my bag, spread out my prayer rug, and began to arrange my things. The historical significance of the place pressed itself upon me. I felt that I was standing upon ground where the footsteps of the Messenger of God had once fallen.

I walked around the area and looked in every direction. Above me the sky was open, while the surrounding hills rose close by. The entrance to the Haram was not very high. My feet seemed reluctant to move forward, as though every step demanded that I understand where I was.

I could not help thinking about the people who had walked here before me. What sort of bodies had they possessed? What colour had they been? What had their faces looked like? The books of history and the genealogies we read preserve names and events, but when one stands upon the earth where those people actually lived, the questions become strangely immediate.

A thought came to me: what physical difference could there really have been between us and them? The same earth lay beneath their feet. They too had walked beneath a sky such as this. Human beings invent distinctions of colour, race, and nation, yet all live upon the same ground and beneath the same heavens.

I looked at the men of different races sitting near the pillars and walls. Their complexions differed; their languages and features differed; yet all had come to the same place. The colours of the world seemed to lose some of their importance there.

I knew that the two hills of Safa and Marwah once stood open and exposed. Their slopes had gradually been cut away as houses and pathways expanded. These were the very hills between which Hagar had run in search of water.

At that time, the area of Zamzam was also much simpler than it is today. If one walked around, one could still recognise traces of the old geography. The sacred places had already been altered by construction, but enough remained to allow a person to imagine the earlier landscape.

The air around the Haram was pleasantly cool. Small birds flew about and settled on the stone. Certain places were marked in ways that recalled events of the past.

One place in particular drew my attention. There stood a stone bearing the words, "This is the home of Umm Hani." Here, it was said, the Messenger of God had stayed and met with those close to him. The place was also associated with the report that, after the acceptance of Islam, Hazrat Umar had come there. Nearby another spot was marked where Dar al-Nadwah had once stood, the council-house in which decisions concerning the affairs of Mecca were made.

Formerly, there had been a small building here, but it had now been demolished. Yet to stand beside Dar al-Nadwah, even in its altered state, was a remarkable experience. Before leaving this place, I think it is necessary to introduce it properly.

Chapter 7

Mecca and the Quraysh Dispute

Everyone knows that Mecca was inhabited by different tribes. Quraysh itself had many branches, and each branch held the position of a small tribe with its own recognised chief. When a matter arose within a clan, it was first taken to that clan's chief. Questions affecting Quraysh as a whole were referred to the chief leader of Mecca.

Quraysh also had a council in which the chiefs of the various clans represented their people. This council dealt with the important affairs of Mecca, while the central chief gave the final decision in major matters. The council met in a building known as Dar al-Nadwah.

Qusayy ibn Kilab had established Dar al-Nadwah. After him, the central leadership passed to Hashim, then to Hashim's brother Muttalib, then to Hashim's grandson Abd al-Muttalib, the grandfather of the Messenger of God, and after Abd al-Muttalib to Abu Talib, peace be upon him.

Thus, at the time when the Messenger of God announced his prophethood, Abu Talib, peace be upon him, was the principal chief of Quraysh. Among the other leading men represented in the council were Amr ibn Hisham, known as Abu Jahl; Umar ibn al-Khattab; Nawfal; Abu Sufyan; Walid ibn Mughirah; As ibn Wa'il; Umayyah ibn Khalaf; and others.

After the Messenger of God announced his prophethood, the relationship between Abu Talib and the council of Quraysh changed. Whatever decision the council made against the Messenger of God, Abu Talib refused to accept it. He openly protected his nephew and the Messenger of God and stood in opposition to the other chiefs of Quraysh.

A cold conflict therefore began between Abu Talib and the Quraysh leadership, and it gradually became more severe.

There were some men, however, who advised Quraysh to leave Muhammad to the other Arabs. They said: "Neither support him nor oppose him. If the rest of Arabia rejects him, your purpose will be achieved without your having to fight him. If the Arabs accept what he says, then his honour will become the honour of Quraysh."

But several influential members of the council rejected this view. Among them were Abu Jahl, chief of Banu Makhzum and the maternal uncle of Umar ibn al-Khattab; Abu Sufyan, chief of Banu Umayyah; Walid ibn Mughirah; Umayyah ibn Khalaf; and others. They

continued their opposition and wished by every means to weaken the influence of Banu Hashim. Yet they feared the strength of Hashim's clan and the authority of Abu Talib.

Two incidents intensified their hostility still further. I shall relate both here.

The First Incident

This was around the seventh year after the announcement of prophethood.

At that time the area around the Kaaba was open. There was sufficient space for circumambulation, and idols belonging to different tribes also stood within that area. The Station of Abraham was protected by a small structure, and Zamzam too was covered. On the southern side there was a doorway and a shaded portico. Quraysh used to sit there for conversation and social gatherings. The ground of the circumambulation area was not paved with marble or any other special flooring. It was simply ordinary earth.

It was afternoon. The Messenger of God was sitting in the shade near the foot of Mount Safa, speaking to a group of people about the oneness of God. He wore a black turban and a light-coloured robe, and leather sandals were on his feet.

Ali ibn Abi Talib was then about sixteen years old. He stood nearby, wearing a sword at his waist. A few other men were also present.

At this time Abu Jahl came toward the Kaaba with two relatives, a Turkish guard, and several men of his clan. His house was in the quarter of Banu Makhzum, toward the south-east of the Kaaba.

As he approached, he saw the Messenger of God. He moved deliberately toward him. The Messenger of God recognised his intention and said to those sitting nearby that, unless Abu Jahl first addressed him, he would not answer him. If Abu Jahl spoke, then he would reply.

Abu Jahl came close and began speaking abusively. He accused the Messenger of God of disturbing the religion of the fathers, of dividing the people, and of seeking leadership over Quraysh. He demanded to know how long he intended to continue speaking against their traditions and gods.

The Messenger of God listened with complete composure. Abu Jahl's anger did not disturb him. He remained where he was and did not respond to the abuse in kind.

This indifference enraged Abu Jahl even more. He had expected a quarrel. Instead, he felt that he was being ignored. He continued muttering, shouting, and saying whatever came into his mind.

The people sitting with the Messenger of God watched quietly. To them, Abu Jahl appeared like a man making a spectacle of himself while the Messenger of God remained entirely unconcerned.

Unable to bear being disregarded, Abu Jahl ordered his guards and relatives to move against the Messenger of God. But they hesitated. They knew the standing of Banu Hashim and feared the consequences.

Seeing their hesitation, Abu Jahl himself moved forward. At once Ali placed his hand on the hilt of his sword.

The motion was enough. Abu Jahl understood the warning. He stopped and did not dare to proceed. Muttering in anger, he withdrew to the gathering of the Quraysh chiefs, where Abu Sufyan and others had been watching.

The purpose behind Abu Jahl's conduct was not merely personal anger. It was part of a plan. The leaders opposed to Banu Hashim wanted to lower the dignity and prestige of the Messenger of God through public humiliation and thereby remove the awe and respect with which people regarded the house of Hashim. Abu Sufyan stood with Abu Jahl in this policy and, according to the author, was among those advising it.

After the incident, the Messenger of God remained for a while near the foot of Safa, then passed by the gathering of the chiefs and returned home.

The men of Quraysh sat in their gathering, silent and thoughtful. Their attempt had failed.

Near the place where this happened stood the two-storeyed house of Abdullah ibn Jud'an, a wealthy and generous man whose house was always open to the poor. One of his slave-girls happened to be standing on the roof and had witnessed the whole incident.

Hamzah, peace be upon him, had been away hunting and had spent a day or two outside Mecca.

Shortly before sunset, Hamzah entered the city on horseback. Holding the reins of his horse, he went directly toward the Kaaba to perform circumambulation, as was his custom after returning from a journey or hunt.

As he passed the house of Abdullah ibn Jud'an, the slave-girl called out to him from the roof: "Abu Umarah, something terrible happened today."

Hamzah stopped and asked, "What happened?"

She told him everything in detail. Hamzah was deeply attached to his nephew. As he listened, anger rose within him. Before she had even finished, he let go of the horse's reins and walked rapidly toward the gathering of the Quraysh chiefs.

Around sixty men were sitting there. Among them was Abu Jahl, who felt proud of what he had done. His guards and relatives were also standing nearby.

Hamzah came forward so quickly and with such fury that the entire gathering fell silent. He did not care about Abu Jahl's guards or relatives. Raising the bow he carried, he struck Abu Jahl in the face with such force that his lip and cheek were torn and blood flowed from his mouth.

The men in the gathering rose in alarm. Abu Jahl's supporters prepared to intervene, but Hamzah challenged them openly.

He warned that if anyone wished to fight him, he was ready. He then declared that the honour of a human being was dearer to God than even the sanctity of the Kaaba. He asked whether they imagined that they could insult a man of his family without consequence.

Then, turning to those present, Hamzah made his position unmistakably clear: "Listen, all of you. I follow the religion of the son of my brother. I accept his faith. From today I stand openly with him. Now tell me: who among you will oppose me?"

No one came forward.

When Abu Jahl realised that even his own supporters were unwilling to fight Hamzah, he tried to calm the matter. He said that Hamzah was right to be angry and that he himself had spoken badly to Muhammad. He pleaded that all of them were descendants of one ancestor and should not shed one another's blood.

After Abu Jahl's apology, Hamzah left the gathering and went directly to the Messenger of God. There he publicly declared his faith.

Abu Jahl suffered severe humiliation from the incident. He blamed his own associates and relatives for failing to assist him and began to consider new plans.

The hostility did not end. Some time later Umar ibn al-Khattab, who was related to Abu Jahl through his mother's family, was also drawn into the conflict. But he too eventually accepted Islam.

For the present, we pass over the remaining details of that episode and turn to the second incident.

The Second Incident

This occurred around the seventh year after the announcement of prophethood.

The Messenger of God often travelled to the settlements around Mecca, sometimes as far as Taif, inviting people to Islam. On such journeys Abu Talib usually arranged for members of Banu Hashim to accompany him for protection. They were told to remain alert and, wherever danger arose, to reach him quickly.

Within the sacred precinct, Quraysh hesitated to shed the Messenger of God's blood openly. Beyond the protected area, however, the danger was greater.

On one occasion the Messenger of God travelled farther than usual to call people to the worship of one God. He went from settlement to settlement and was delayed in returning.

When he did not return at the expected time, Abu Talib became deeply anxious. He feared that Quraysh had secretly killed his nephew. He sent people in different directions to search for him, but no reliable news came back.

By this period Abu Talib had stopped attending Dar al-Nadwah because relations with the Quraysh leadership had become too strained. The chiefs continued to gather there, especially in the evenings. They discussed their affairs, listened to poets and storytellers, and spoke repeatedly against the Messenger of God and Banu Hashim.

Believing that his nephew might have been killed, Abu Talib gathered the young men of Banu Hashim. He ordered every one of them to place a sword beneath his clothing.

He told them: "Come with me to Dar al-Nadwah. When I give you the signal, draw your swords and kill all the leading men of Quraysh who are present. The blood of one drop from my son's heart is dearer to me than all the chiefs of Quraysh. If Muhammad has been killed, none of them will remain alive."

The young men accepted his order.

They entered Dar al-Nadwah and positioned themselves among the chiefs. Abu Talib stood before them, ready to give the signal.

Before the command was issued, however, news arrived that the Messenger of God was alive and had been found.

Abu Talib immediately withdrew his men.

The following day he returned to the gathering of Quraysh. This time he openly told them what he had intended.

He said: “Yesterday I believed that you had killed Muhammad. These young men whom you see around you each carried a sword beneath his garment. Had Muhammad been killed, I would have given them the signal and not one of your chiefs would have left this room alive.”

He then made clear that the protection of the Messenger of God was not an empty claim. Banu Hashim was prepared to defend him with its blood.

The chiefs of Quraysh understood the seriousness of the warning. After this, open physical aggression against the Messenger of God became more dangerous. The opponents therefore began considering another method.

Other Reasons Behind the Boycott

The boycott of Banu Hashim is usually presented as though Quraysh suddenly decided upon it merely because the Messenger of God preached Islam. The matter was more complicated.

The chiefs opposing Abu Talib had several objectives. They wanted to isolate the Messenger of God, weaken the economic strength of Banu Hashim, and reduce Abu Talib's political authority.

They also hoped that if Abu Talib died during the period of isolation, the central leadership of Mecca would pass into the hands of their own faction. Once this happened, they could dominate the council without facing a chief powerful enough to restrain them.

Thus the dispute was religious, political, social, and economic at the same time.

Abu Jahl and his allies therefore proposed that the entire tribe of Banu Hashim should be subjected to a social and economic boycott. No one was to trade with them, marry among them, or maintain ordinary social relations with them. Any outside tribe that supported them would also face pressure.

Abu Sufyan and those aligned with him supported the proposal.

After prolonged discussion, the chiefs finally agreed upon a written pact.

One morning they gathered in Dar al-Nadwah and began dictating the terms. Abu Jahl and Abu Sufyan were among the leading organisers. Mansur ibn Ikrimah was appointed to write the document.

Mansur ibn Ikrimah ibn Mukharrimah was a poet associated with the tribe of Qays ibn Aylan. He earned his living through poetry. When tribes went to war, poets accompanied

them, recited martial verses, and praised their own side. Sometimes Mansur himself also entered the fighting.

The writing of this oppressive agreement was one of the last major acts of his life. Not long afterward his hand was afflicted and he died.

The agreement was written down and hung in the Kaaba so that no one could easily alter it.

Its provisions were, in substance, as follows:

1. No one was to maintain ordinary relations with Muhammad and those who supported him.
2. Economic and social dealings with Banu Hashim were prohibited.
3. Marriage with members of Banu Hashim was prohibited.
4. If any tribe entered into conflict with Banu Hashim, Quraysh would support that tribe, regardless of whether Banu Hashim was in the right.
5. No assistance was to be given to Banu Hashim.
6. The agreement was to remain in force until Muhammad's movement had been brought to an end.
7. Anyone entering Mecca was forbidden to trade with Banu Hashim. Anyone who violated this prohibition could have his goods confiscated.
8. During the pilgrimage season, merchants were to be prevented from selling to Muslims and Banu Hashim at normal prices.
9. If any Arab tribe fought Banu Hashim, Quraysh would assist that tribe and join the fighting against Banu Hashim.

With the exception of Banu Adi, the leading men of Quraysh accepted the terms. The agreement was publicly proclaimed throughout Mecca so that everyone would know that anyone assisting Banu Hashim would expose himself to retaliation.

When the boycott was announced, Abu Talib gathered Banu Hashim at his house. Sitting in the room once used by his father Abd al-Muttalib, he reminded them of the covenant their ancestor had made to protect members of the clan.

He told them:

“My people, until today I have carried the responsibility of protecting Muhammad, the Messenger of God. From the first day I knew the weight of this burden. You have stood with me and helped me. Our enemies now believe that by isolating us they can force our shoulders to bend and make us abandon him.

“They are mistaken.

“If anyone among you is unwilling to endure what is coming, he is free to leave today. But as for me, even if I must bear the whole burden alone, I shall carry it until my Lord decides the matter.

“Mountains of hardship may be placed upon us. Ribs may break beneath their weight and men may fall exhausted. Yet Muhammad is our trust. We shall protect him, and we shall not abandon him.”

The members of Banu Hashim affirmed their support. They said that wherever he led them, they would follow.

The Withdrawal to Shi'b Abi Talib

Abu Talib then removed his relatives from their homes in Mecca and gathered them in a narrow valley between two mountains. The place became known as Shi'b Abi Talib.

I am standing there as I write these lines.

Abu Talib arranged the settlement carefully. Tents and simple dwellings were set against the mountain slopes. Animals were kept in the broader, lower part of the valley, while the more protected places were used for people.

Hamzah was instructed to take charge of hunting and provisions. The young men of Banu Hashim were assigned to guard the approaches and watch for enemy movement.

At night they performed the duties of sentries around the Messenger of God.

Abu Talib had chosen this valley deliberately. The quarter of Banu Hashim inside Mecca could be approached from several directions and was vulnerable to a surprise attack. Shi'b Abi Talib, by contrast, lay between steep slopes and could effectively be approached from only one principal direction. A small number of defenders could therefore guard it.

Banu Hashim spent approximately three years in the valley.

Abu Talib had prepared as much as possible in advance. He sold or converted into usable resources whatever wealth could be mobilised. His property in Taif and the income from an orchard near Mecca were also used to sustain the people.

Yet a community of roughly a hundred persons, together with animals, could not survive indefinitely when the supply of food was being deliberately obstructed.

Even during the boycott, however, the Messenger of God continued to leave the valley during the pilgrimage season and invite visitors to Islam. Men of Banu Hashim accompanied him as guards under the supervision of Hamzah.

The leaders of Quraysh disliked this intensely. They came repeatedly to Abu Talib and demanded that he hand Muhammad over to them. They said that if he surrendered him, they would kill him and the dispute would end.

Abu Talib rejected them with a severe warning. He told them, in substance:

“O wrongdoers and men who have gone beyond all bounds, has he committed any crime for which he deserves to die? Turn your eyes toward your own conduct. Do not advance against a man protected by his people like hungry cattle rushing upon fodder.

“By God, whoever stretches his hand toward him will have to pass over our bodies first.”

The men withdrew, disturbed by the firmness of his answer.

Abu Talib nevertheless knew that an assassination attempt might be made at night. He therefore took special precautions.

When the Messenger of God lay down to sleep, Abu Talib sometimes waited until others had seen where he was lying. Later, under cover of darkness, he would move him to another place and put one of his own sons in the bed from which the Messenger of God had been moved.

In this way an assassin entering at night would not know where the Messenger of God was actually sleeping.

The Condition of Banu Hashim

The confinement in Shi'b Abi Talib lasted for about three years.

The roads were watched so closely that only with great difficulty could food be carried into the valley. Nevertheless, some people of Mecca secretly helped Banu Hashim.

Among them were Abu al-As ibn al-Rabi and Hisham ibn Amr. At night they sometimes loaded grain or other provisions onto a camel, brought it near the entrance to the valley, and released it so that it would wander toward Banu Hashim.

Occasionally Quraysh discovered such efforts, and serious quarrels followed.

During these years the Messenger of God, Khadijah, and Abu Talib endured extreme hardship. Much of the expense of maintaining those in the valley was borne from the personal wealth of Khadijah and Abu Talib.

A number of people in the valley were not Muslims. They remained there because they were members of Banu Hashim and regarded the defence of their kin as a tribal obligation.

Women who had married outside the clan were sometimes willing to leave the valley and stay with their husbands' families, but not all did so. Families were divided and ordinary relations were disrupted.

As time passed, the accumulated wealth of Banu Hashim was steadily consumed. Houses and property were sold. Resources diminished until even people who had once lived comfortably began to experience hunger.

For three years they lived in this condition.

Then one night Hisham ibn Amr, who had been troubled by what he saw, met Zuhayr ibn Abi Umayyah.

Hisham asked him:

“Are you satisfied to eat well, wear good clothes, and live among your family while your maternal relatives are confined in the valley? If Abu Jahl and Abu Sufyan's own relatives were suffering like this, would they tolerate it?”

Zuhayr replied: “What can I do alone? If I had others with me, I would stand against this agreement.”

Hisham then went to Mut'im ibn Adi and brought him into the plan. After that he approached Abu al-Bakhtari and Zam'ah ibn al-Aswad. In this way five men agreed that the boycott had become intolerable and should be ended.

Zuhayr said that when they gathered in Dar al-Nadwah, he would raise the matter first. The others should then support him one after another so that the opposition would not appear to come from a single man.

They agreed.

The next day, when the chiefs had gathered, Zuhayr rose and said:

“People of Mecca, are we to eat food, wear clothes, marry, and live comfortably while Banu Hashim have been shut away for three years? By God, I shall not sit down until this unjust document is torn apart.”

Abu Jahl angrily replied that the document would never be torn up. He claimed that the survival and unity of Quraysh depended upon it and that ending the boycott would lead to civil conflict.

Zam'ah ibn al-Aswad stood and answered that the honour and position of Quraysh had always depended in large measure upon Banu Hashim. He said that he had not truly approved the agreement even when it was written and now openly supported its destruction.

Abu al-Bakhtari then rose and declared that the oppression had gone beyond what any honourable man could tolerate.

Abu Sufyan attempted to oppose them. He asked whether they intended to reopen divisions among Quraysh and destroy the unity that had made the tribe strong among the Arabs.

Mut'im ibn Adi answered him sharply:

“What unity are you speaking of? Are Banu Hashim not also Quraysh? Are they not of the same ancestry as we are?

“You eat while they starve. You live freely while they and their children suffer. And you call this the preservation of Quraysh?

“What will the Arab tribes say of us? They will say that Quraysh destroys its own brothers.

“I opposed this cruel pact when it was made, and I oppose it today.”

Others in the assembly now began to speak in the same way. The opposition was no longer confined to five men. A visible majority had begun to regret the boycott.

That same evening the Messenger of God informed Abu Talib of something remarkable.

He said: “Uncle, God has sent an insect against the document they wrote concerning us. It has eaten everything in it except the name of God.”

Abu Talib immediately rose.

He went to the Kaaba, performed circumambulation, kissed the Black Stone, and then went to the assembly of Quraysh. The chiefs were surprised to see him after such a long absence and turned toward him in silence.

Abu Talib stood with dignity and addressed them.

“People of Mecca,” he said, “Quraysh has treated us unjustly. You planned against our family, declared us criminals, drove us from our homes, and forced us to seek refuge in a barren mountain valley.

“Even those among us who had not accepted Muhammad’s faith were subjected to the same suffering merely because they belonged to our family.

“My nephew has now told me that the document you wrote against us has been destroyed by an insect. Everything in it has been eaten except the name of God.

“Bring out the document and look at it.

“If what my nephew has told me is false, I shall hand him over to you and you may do with him as you please. But if what he has said is true, then end this cruel social and economic boycott.”

Those present immediately went toward the Kaaba.

The keeper of the Kaaba was summoned, the door was opened, and the document was brought out under the supervision of the chiefs.

They were astonished.

It was exactly as the Messenger of God had said. The writing had been eaten away except for the name of God.

The people cried out together that the agreement was finished.

Abu Jahl and Abu Sufyan could no longer maintain their position. They gathered their things and withdrew, while the majority accepted the termination of the boycott.

Where Was Shi’b Abi Talib?

During my first visit, I spent three nights in Shi’b Abi Talib. I walked through the valley repeatedly, moving from one end to the other.

I found it difficult to imagine exactly where Abu Talib, the Messenger of God, Hamzah, Ali, and the other members of Banu Hashim had lived. Perhaps I was standing where the Messenger of God’s bed had once been. Perhaps Abu Talib’s sons had slept on one side of him while Abu Talib himself lay on the other.

Abu Talib, in my view, did not occupy the valley for the first time during the boycott. The valley appears to have been connected with him earlier and was probably used as a place

for grazing animals and storing grain. He knew the ground, its entrances, and its defensive advantages.

Gradually I climbed upward until I reached the summit of one of the surrounding hills. From there the Kaaba and the sanctuary could be seen below.

Much of the hill has now been cut away. If the present construction continues, the remaining traces may disappear within another generation.

From above, one can still understand the shape of the place. Mountains surround it, with a narrow low area in the middle. In Abu Talib's time this would have provided a protected enclosure for livestock. Grain could be stored, animals tethered, and people accommodated along the slopes.

Thus Shi'b Abu Talib should not be imagined simply as a prison into which the family was suddenly thrown. It was a place already known to Abu Talib and suited to the defence of a large household under siege.

The Falsehood

Since the discussion has reached Abu Talib, another matter should also be considered.

Abu Talib lived only a short time after the boycott ended. Everyone knows the hostility that later political forces developed toward Islam's first household and toward the Ahl al-Bayt of the Messenger of God. After the Messenger of God's death, court-sponsored narrators and writers spread reports so widely that generations of Muslims came to accept many claims about the Prophet's family without serious examination.

One of these claims concerns the faith of Abu Talib.

Ali, peace be upon him, is reported to have said that the enemy of a man's religion is often found among those closest to him.

Let us therefore examine the famous narration used to claim that Abu Talib died without accepting Islam.

The narration is commonly related in the following form:

Musayyib ibn Hazn is said to have reported that when Abu Talib was close to death, the Messenger of God came to him. Abu Jahl and Abdullah ibn Abi Umayyah were also present. The Messenger of God said, "Uncle, say *La ilaha illa Allah*, a word by which I may plead for you before God."

Abu Jahl and Abdullah ibn Abi Umayyah then said, “Abu Talib, will you abandon the religion of Abd al-Muttalib?”

They continued speaking to him until, according to the narration, Abu Talib’s last words were: “I remain upon the religion of Abd al-Muttalib.”

This report is then used as proof that Abu Talib did not die a Muslim.

Let us examine it.

There are two men presented as direct witnesses and one principal transmitter.

The alleged witnesses are:

1. Abu Jahl.
2. Abdullah ibn Abi Umayyah.

The principal narrator is:

1. Musayyib ibn Hazn.

The first two were at that time enemies of the Messenger of God and of Abu Talib. They were neither members of the Prophet’s household nor close relatives of Abu Talib. They belonged to the very opposition that had spent years trying to destroy Banu Hashim.

Only a short time had passed since the end of the boycott when Abu Talib died.

My question is therefore simple: what were these two enemies doing inside Abu Talib’s house at the moment of his death?

For years they had worked against him. They had tried to bring about the death of the Messenger of God. Abu Talib’s sons, daughters, relatives, and women of the household would have been present around him.

Who allowed Abu Jahl and Abdullah ibn Abi Umayyah to enter that private room?

If they truly were present, where is the independent evidence?

As for Abu Jahl, everyone knows that he later died fighting against the Muslims at Badr.

Abdullah ibn Abi Umayyah, according to the author’s argument, remained opposed to the Prophet for years and accepted Islam only much later.

How then do these two men become the foundation of a report about the final faith of Abu Talib?

Now consider the principal transmitter, Musayyib ibn Hazn.

He accepted Islam much later, at the conquest of Mecca. When he came to the Messenger of God, the Prophet asked his name. He answered, “Musayyib ibn Hazn.”

The Messenger of God told him to change the unpleasant meaning of the name. Musayyib refused, saying that it was the name his father had given him and he would not alter it.

The point is not the name itself. The point is this: a man who resisted even such a simple instruction from the Messenger of God is made the decisive transmitter of a report through which Muslims are asked to judge the faith of Abu Talib.

Moreover, Musayyib himself was not present at Abu Talib’s death.

He therefore had to receive the report from others. And those “others,” according to the chain placed before us, are precisely Abu Jahl and Abdullah ibn Abi Umayyah, whose hostility has already been described.

Thus the narration does not contain a trustworthy eyewitness from Abu Talib’s own family.

There is more.

The report was transmitted through Sa’id ibn al-Musayyib, the son of Musayyib. Sa’id is counted among the narrators frequently cited in Sunni collections, and many reports hostile to the Ahl al-Bayt passed through circles of this kind.

One incident concerning Sa’id ibn al-Musayyib is revealing.

When Imam Ali ibn Husayn, Zayn al-Abidin, died and his funeral prayer was held, people who possessed even a small degree of love and respect for the Ahl al-Bayt hurried to attend.

According to the report, a man saw Sa’id ibn al-Musayyib moving away from the funeral so that he would not take part. He asked him, “Sa’id, what prevents you from attending the funeral of Zayn al-Abidin?”

Sa’id replied that he would rather pray two rak’ahs by himself than attend the funeral.

This, the author says, is the man whose words Muslims are asked to accept when the faith of Abu Talib is questioned.

It is astonishing that generations of Muslims have rested such a serious accusation upon such a chain of transmission.

Nor did the polemical tradition stop with Abu Talib. Reports were also produced that cast doubt upon the faith of other members of the Prophet’s ancestry. Abd al-Muttalib himself was sometimes described as an unbeliever.

Yet this is the same Abd al-Muttalib who, when the army of the Elephant approached the Kaaba, prayed to God for the protection of the House and whose prayer, according to the same historical tradition, was answered.

It is the same Abd al-Muttalib who served the pilgrims, cared for the sanctuary, and whose religious legacy remained a recognised point of honour among his descendants.

How then can one accept without examination narratives that condemn such men merely because later political and sectarian interests required it?

The matter of Abu Talib's faith, therefore, cannot be settled by repeating a narration whose alleged witnesses were his enemies and whose transmitters were themselves associated with hostility toward the Ahl al-Bayt.

His entire life must be considered: his protection of the Messenger of God, his public defence of him, the sacrifices he made, the three years of boycott he endured, the danger to which he exposed his own sons in order to safeguard Muhammad, and the unwavering support he gave to the Prophet's mission.

These are not minor details. They are the historical record by which Abu Talib must be judged.

Chapter 8

The Story of Hajun

One day I left the area of Abu Talib's house and walked toward Hajun, a hill lying to the north of the Kaaba, roughly three kilometres away. Jannat al-Mu'alla, the cemetery of Mecca, extends toward its far side. Hajun was associated especially with Banu Hashim, and many members of that family were buried there. The grandfather and uncles of the Messenger of God, and others who died before the Hijrah, were laid to rest around the lower slopes of this hill. Anyone travelling from Mecca toward the northern routes, including the road to Medina, would pass by Hajun.

When I saw the hill in 1993, it still looked like a hill should. A narrow, winding road climbed through it. Here and there were small shrubs and patches of grass growing among the stones. There were also old graves, marked only by a few stones. Between the graves stood small bushes, and a date-palm tree was also visible. No one was then being buried in that old part of the cemetery.

This time, however, the place seemed completely transformed. The hillside had been turned into a landscaped, controlled area, with fences and new arrangements everywhere. So much had changed that it was difficult to recognise what I had seen before.

The graves associated with the Ahl al-Bayt - particularly those of Abd al-Muttalib, Abu Talib, Khadijah, and other relatives of the Messenger of God - had been enclosed behind barriers. The old grave-markers had been reduced to simple signs. At the gate, little more was written than an indication that Khadijah's grave lay there.

When I first came here in 1993, I asked someone to show me the grave of Abd al-Muttalib. The man did not know. There were two Bedouins nearby, and I asked them, "Which grave is Abu Talib's, and which is Khadijah's?"

My question left them confused. They looked at one another. One of them was a young man. I gave him a few riyals and he became more willing to help. He climbed part of the hill with me and pointed out three places. One, he said, was the grave of Umm al-Mu'minin Khadijah; another was the grave of Abd al-Muttalib; and a third, he said, belonged to a son of the Messenger of God.

I continued walking among the graves and reciting the ziyarat of those buried there.

These were the people who had been among the closest companions and supporters of the Messenger of God. The Qur'an itself remembers some of them and the sacrifices they made. Yet the people around Hajun seemed to know very little about them. I remember thinking that ordinary Muslims had forgotten much of their own history. I had felt this elsewhere in Pakistan as well, but here the contrast was even more striking.

In those days the space from Hajun toward the Kaaba was still comparatively open. There were simple local houses and small settlements. In the markets one could find African, Yemeni, Syrian, and other imported goods. Similar products were sold elsewhere in Mecca as well, and pilgrims often bought small objects as souvenirs and blessings.

As I walked from Jannat al-Mu'alla toward Hajun, I saw a young Arab boy racing a motorcycle along the cemetery pathways as though the place were an ordinary road. No one stopped him. I did not wish to become absorbed in the conduct of other people, however. Whenever I came to Mecca, I found myself turning instead toward my own faith and toward what this city meant to me.

How Much Has Been Erased?

Thirty-five years later I returned, and almost everything had changed.

Abu Talib's house, the house of Abbas where Imam Husayn spent the last four months of his stay in Mecca, the old places connected with sacrifice, the site associated with Zamzam, and many other landmarks had either disappeared or been altered so completely that hardly a trace remained. The area around Zamzam had been rebuilt and absorbed into new construction. Mecca had, in many respects, been turned into a vast commercial centre.

The people who live here, and many of those who come from other countries for Hajj and Umrah, know almost nothing about these places. Many do not even seem to know why they have come. Yet by walking on foot I was still able to discover a few things for myself.

One day I walked about thirty-five kilometres through different parts of the area. Two places in particular produced a strange feeling in me. One was the plain of Arafat and Jabal al-Rahmah, the hill associated in tradition with Adam, peace be upon him. The other was a high place from which, looking down in every direction, one feels surrounded by a strangely timeless atmosphere.

I shall explain that feeling later.

I was also searching for the house in Mecca where Husayn had stayed - a house I had seen on my first visit. The building itself was no longer there, though the ground on which it had stood was still empty. A few small trees had been planted there.

I tried to trace the route by which Husayn, peace be upon him, had left Mecca for Karbala. As I followed it, another question returned to me: why did Husayn leave Mecca on the eighth of Dhu al-Hijjah?

The answer came to me at Arafat.

What that answer was I have described in my novel *The Traveller to Kufa*. Anyone who wants the full answer will have to read the novel.

Let me mention a few things briefly.

Mecca is a vast valley, as I noted earlier in this book - broad enough to contain millions of people. Today its climate is comparatively moderate, and its winds are not always scorching and dry. The spring here has a peculiar fragrance of its own. Roads emerge between the surrounding mountains in many directions.

You may think of old Mecca as something like a great terminal. Fourteen hundred years ago, and even earlier, trading caravans, travellers seeking work, and other wayfarers passed through it on routes linking different lands. They would stop in Mecca or in the nearby settlements, conduct their business, rest, and then continue onward.

After rain, soft grass grows on the smaller and larger hills, enough to feed large numbers of camels and goats. The people passing through this region came from different linguistic and cultural backgrounds and therefore brought many languages, habits, and customs into contact with one another.

I also noticed something else. Roads, schools, hotels, and other buildings bearing the names of Aishah, her father Abu Bakr, and Umar are easy to find.

What I did not see were comparable places bearing the names of the family of Muhammad and the descendants of Ali. During the days I spent here after Hajj, I encountered scarcely anything visibly associated with them, apart from Hajun itself.

There is much more that could be said, but these few observations are enough for now.

Chapter 9

The Story of the Cave of Hira

I went to see the Cave of Hira. It lies to the north of Mecca, high on Jabal al-Nur. By the road, the mountain is about ten kilometres from the city. A paved road now leads toward it, and taxis carry visitors there. I hired one and travelled with several other pilgrims who, like me, wanted to see the place connected with the beginning of revelation.

The mountain rises steeply from the surrounding ground. At its foot are shops and small stalls where visitors can buy water, food, and other necessities before beginning the climb. The path upward is rough. Some stretches have been shaped into steps, but much of the ascent remains difficult, particularly in the heat.

People of every age were climbing. Some moved quickly, while others had to stop again and again to recover their breath. Bottles of water were carried in the hand, and people rested wherever a patch of shade could be found.

As I climbed, I kept thinking about the old descriptions of the place. The mountain today is approached by a route that has been altered considerably. Roads, buildings, concrete work, and the movement of visitors have changed the surroundings. It is therefore not easy to reconstruct exactly what the area looked like fourteen centuries ago.

The climb itself is demanding. It is not the sort of place to which a person could casually walk every day without effort. Even after modern paths have been made, one has to climb for a long time over uneven ground. In earlier centuries the ascent must have been still more difficult.

At several points I stopped and looked back toward Mecca. The city lies below, spread among the mountains. From this height the built-up area seems distant, and the noise of the city fades away.

When I eventually reached the upper part of the mountain, I found that the place called the Cave of Hira is not a deep cave in the ordinary sense. It is a narrow space formed between large rocks. A person can enter it, sit inside, and look out through an opening. The space is small, and only a few people can fit there comfortably at one time.

Visitors crowded around it. Some wanted to pray inside; some simply wished to see it; others touched the rocks or stood in silence. Because of the crowd, a person could not remain there for long.

I looked at the place carefully.

From the opening, one can see toward Mecca. In earlier times, before the modern city expanded, the view must have been far more open. The Kaaba would have stood alone in the valley with comparatively few houses around it.

I had read many accounts about the Messenger of God spending long periods here in solitude before the beginning of revelation. Standing in the place itself, however, raised several questions in my mind.

If he came here repeatedly and remained for days at a time, food and water would have had to be carried up the mountain. The climb is not easy. A person descending to Mecca and returning again would expend great effort. It is therefore necessary to understand what the reports actually mean rather than simply repeat them without reflection.

It is also said that Khadijah brought provisions to him. Yet anyone who has climbed this mountain will immediately ask how frequently such a journey could reasonably have been made, especially by an older woman. The physical conditions of the route have to be considered.

The purpose of these questions is not to deny that the Messenger of God came to the mountain. The point is that historical reports often acquire details over time, and those details must be tested against the geography and practical realities of the place.

When I sat near the rocks, I tried to imagine the mountain as it had once been: no paved road, no shops, no crowds, no modern buildings, no electric lights. There would have been only stone, sky, wind, and the distant valley below.

The solitude of such a place is easy to understand.

But the picture often presented in popular storytelling - of a man continually leaving his home, climbing the mountain, and remaining in a tiny rocky opening for prolonged periods - deserves closer examination.

Jabal al-Nur is about eight hundred metres high. Even today the climb is exhausting. Anyone who wishes to understand the traditional account should first make the ascent and see the place for himself.

Why, then, do the reports say that the Messenger of God went there?

Before answering, it is necessary to consider another well-known story.

Why Were Messengers Sent to the Mountains?

Throughout religious literature one finds mountains associated with decisive moments in the lives of prophets. Moses is connected with Sinai. Other prophets are likewise described as withdrawing into lonely places.

There is a natural reason for this. A mountain separates a person from the noise and ordinary pressures of society. Solitude allows thought to deepen. A person who is troubled by the corruption, injustice, or confusion around him may seek such a place in order to reflect.

The Messenger of God lived in a society filled with conflict, tribal rivalry, commercial competition, inherited customs, and religious practices with which he was increasingly dissatisfied. It is therefore entirely understandable that he should sometimes withdraw from the city.

But one must still distinguish between this reasonable historical possibility and every detail later attached to it.

I have repeatedly said that history should be examined through geography, chronology, social conditions, and human possibility. A report does not become unquestionable merely because generations have repeated it.

As I looked down from Jabal al-Nur, this principle became even clearer to me. Below lay the routes, settlements, and valleys through which people had moved for centuries. The landscape itself often corrects the imagination created by books.

One can understand why a person might come here for solitude.

What is more difficult to accept without examination is the elaborate form in which the story has often been told.

The mountain is not detached from the world. It overlooks inhabited territory. People could move through the surrounding valleys. Shepherds, travellers, and hunters must have known the area. It was not an unknown wilderness.

Nor is the so-called cave a hidden chamber deep inside the mountain. It is a narrow shelter among rocks.

These facts matter.

The event that gave Hira its importance is the beginning of revelation. According to the familiar account, the angel Gabriel came to the Messenger of God while he was in the

cave and commanded him to read. The Prophet replied that he could not read. The command was repeated, and the opening verses of Surah al-'Alaq were then revealed.

This is the account known to every Muslim.

Yet the reports describing the event differ in important details. Some say the Prophet was asleep; others that he was awake. Some describe Gabriel as appearing in bodily form; others do not. Some reports say that the Prophet was pressed or embraced until he could scarcely bear it.

The author finds these embellishments difficult to reconcile with the dignity of revelation and the character of the Messenger of God.

Revelation, in his view, should not be imagined as a scene of terror in which the Messenger of God did not understand what was happening and had to be physically overpowered before receiving the word of God.

The Qur'an itself presents revelation as a deliberate divine communication. It does not describe the Messenger of God as becoming a prophet through a frightening encounter whose meaning he could not understand.

I therefore came down from Jabal al-Nur with more questions than I had carried upward.

I had seen the place. I had measured its physical reality against the stories I had heard. The result was not disbelief in revelation; it was distrust of the unnecessary dramatic details with which later narrators surrounded it.

The Story of the Cave of Thawr

The story of the Cave of Thawr is also well known.

Jabal Thawr lies to the south of Mecca, and the cave associated with the Hijrah is situated high on the mountain. When the Messenger of God left Mecca for Medina, the traditional account says that he and Abu Bakr took refuge there for several days while the Quraysh searched for them.

Visitors are shown the cave today, and many make the difficult climb to see it.

The mountain is surrounded by rough ground. There is no easy natural approach. Modern paths have made the journey somewhat simpler, but it remains strenuous. A person who climbs it quickly understands that anyone seeking refuge there would have chosen a place that required considerable effort to reach.

The popular story contains several familiar details.

It is said that when the pursuers reached the mouth of the cave, a spider had spun a web across the entrance and a pair of pigeons had made a nest there. Seeing the untouched web and the birds, the pursuers concluded that no one could have entered and turned away.

The story is repeated so often that many people assume it to be part of the Qur'anic account.

It is not.

The Qur'an mentions the Prophet and his companion in the cave and records the words, "Do not grieve; indeed, God is with us." It does not mention a spider, pigeons, eggs, or a miraculous web.

These details come from later reports.

The author therefore asks a simple question: if the Quraysh had been searching seriously for the Messenger of God and had tracked him as far as the mountain, would a spider's web really have prevented them from looking inside a cave?

A pursuer who believes that the man he seeks may be only a few steps away does not abandon the search merely because of a web. He brushes it aside and looks.

The difficulty becomes greater when the geography is considered.

If a person enters a cave in order to hide, the value of the place depends on whether he can be seen, whether there are alternate openings, and whether pursuers can reach him. The actual shape of the cave therefore matters more than the picturesque details that later storytellers added.

The Reality of the Cave

The geography around Mecca is rugged. Hills rise one behind another, and rocky cavities are common. A person travelling through these mountains can find many places in which to rest or conceal himself temporarily.

A cave is therefore not, by itself, extraordinary.

The historical importance comes from what happened there.

To understand the Hijrah, one must first remember the political situation in Mecca. By that time the conflict between the Messenger of God and the leading opponents of Quraysh had become intense. The Muslims had begun leaving for Yathrib, and the Quraysh feared that a new centre of power was forming outside Mecca.

The chiefs therefore met to decide what should be done with Muhammad.

According to the common account, they resolved that young men from different clans should strike him together so that the responsibility for his blood would be divided among the tribes. Banu Hashim would then be unable to fight all Quraysh at once.

The Messenger of God was informed of the danger and prepared to leave.

Ali, peace be upon him, remained behind in Mecca and slept in the Prophet's bed so that those watching the house would not immediately know that he had gone. The Messenger of God then left the city.

Here again the traditional narratives contain many dramatic details, and here again the author urges caution.

The opponents of the Messenger of God were not fools. They knew the roads around Mecca. They had traders, hunters, guides, and tribesmen familiar with the region. If they organised a serious pursuit, they would not merely run about at random.

The Hijrah therefore required planning.

The route to Medina normally led north, yet the Messenger of God first moved south. This was a sensible way to mislead pursuers. By going toward Thawr rather than immediately taking the northern road, he created distance between himself and the obvious route to Yathrib.

This does not require legendary explanations. It is intelligent strategy.

It is also reported that arrangements were made for food and information to reach the travellers while they remained away from the main road. Such arrangements likewise suggest careful planning.

The Messenger of God did not simply flee into the night without preparation.

The question is how long he remained in the cave and exactly what occurred there.

Traditional accounts often say three nights. The author does not reject the possibility, but he insists that chronology and distance must be examined carefully. The movements of the search parties, the availability of food and water, and the subsequent route toward Medina all have to fit together.

The point is not to strip the Hijrah of its spiritual meaning. It is to restore its human intelligence.

The Messenger of God acted with courage, but courage does not mean recklessness. He took precautions, used knowledge of the terrain, arranged support, and moved in a way that made pursuit difficult.

The Qur'an's statement about the cave is brief and powerful. The Messenger of God tells his companion not to grieve because God is with them.

That verse does not require pigeons, eggs, or a spider's web in order to be meaningful.

Indeed, the more one loads the story with unnecessary wonders, the easier it becomes to lose sight of the actual greatness of the event: a hunted man, carrying a mission that had transformed Mecca, leaves his city under threat of death and begins the journey that will change the political history of Arabia.

The cave was one stage in that journey.

The Narrations About Abu Bakr

The presence of Abu Bakr in the cave is firmly embedded in the traditional account, and the Qur'anic verse refers to the Messenger of God as one of two and to his companion.

Later narrators, however, expanded the story greatly.

Some reports describe Abu Bakr as becoming intensely frightened. Others say that he wept because he feared for the Messenger of God. Some say that he was worried for himself. Still others present long conversations supposedly held inside the cave.

These reports do not all agree.

The author therefore argues that one should remain with what can be established. The Messenger of God had a companion with him; they were in a cave during the Hijrah; danger existed outside; and the Messenger of God reassured his companion with trust in God.

Beyond this, details require evidence.

The same principle applies to reports that transform every movement into a miracle.

Suppose pursuers came close to the cave and did not enter. There may have been many ordinary reasons. They may not have thought the fugitives had gone south. They may have searched a different part of the mountain. They may have concluded from tracks that the men had gone elsewhere. The terrain itself may have concealed the entrance.

History does not become less religious because natural causes are considered.

God's help can operate through planning, geography, courage, loyal companions, darkness, timing, and human judgment just as surely as through an extraordinary event.

The author therefore prefers the simpler understanding unless strong evidence requires something more.

The Beginning of Revelation Reconsidered

The story of Hira must finally be considered together with the broader question of revelation.

The Messenger of God was not an empty-minded man who suddenly became religious at the age of forty. He had lived among the people of Mecca, travelled with caravans, observed the beliefs of Jews, Christians, and Arabian tribes, and thought deeply about the moral condition of his society.

He knew the Kaaba and its history. He knew the traditions connected with Abraham and Ishmael. He knew the injustices committed in trade and tribal life. He knew the position of the weak, the orphan, the slave, and the poor.

When revelation began, therefore, it addressed a mind already engaged with the condition of humanity.

The Qur'an repeatedly calls upon people to think, observe, remember, and reason. It speaks of the heavens, the earth, the creation of the human being, the rise and fall of earlier peoples, and the moral consequences of human conduct.

The opening of revelation should be understood within this intellectual and moral setting.

The command to read was not an isolated magical word. It marked the beginning of a message that would continually call human beings toward knowledge, reflection, and accountability.

Later narrators sometimes portrayed the Messenger of God as returning from Hira in such terror that he did not know whether what had happened to him was divine or demonic. They then made Khadijah take him to Waraqah ibn Nawfal, who supposedly informed him that the being he had encountered was the same angel who had come to Moses.

The author considers this version deeply problematic.

Could the Messenger of God receive revelation from God and yet require another man to tell him that he was a prophet?

Could Gabriel bring the divine message and leave the recipient uncertain whether he had encountered an angel or something evil?

Could the first certainty of prophethood come not from revelation itself but from the opinion of Waraqah?

These questions, in the author's view, expose the weakness of the later narrative.

The Messenger of God knew the source of his revelation. He did not need a third person to certify Gabriel for him.

Khadijah's role should likewise not be reduced to that of a frightened wife trying to find someone who could explain her husband's experience. She was the first person to believe in him and stood beside him with extraordinary loyalty. Her faith was based on knowledge of his character and confidence in his truthfulness, not on a certificate from Waraqah.

The famous story says that after the first revelation Khadijah took the Messenger of God to Waraqah, who was old and blind. Waraqah listened and announced that the same heavenly messenger who had come to Moses had now come to Muhammad. He is then said to have wished that he might remain alive until Muhammad's people drove him from Mecca.

But if Waraqah had recognised the truth so clearly, what role did he play afterward? Why do the reports not preserve a sustained record of his support? Why is his significance concentrated almost entirely in this one dramatic scene?

The author regards the story as a later attempt to place a Christian or scriptural authority between the Messenger of God and his own certainty of prophethood.

That is unnecessary.

The Qur'an does not depend upon Waraqah.

Revelation came from God to His Messenger.

The Messenger of God understood his mission and began to proclaim it.

The first believers accepted him because they knew him, knew his character, and heard the message he brought.

A Mountain of Black Rock

Jabal al-Nur itself is a mountain of dark stone. Its great rocks lie one upon another, exposed to the sun. In hot weather they become intensely heated; in cooler weather the wind moves sharply across them.

From the upper slopes the view is clear. The valleys and ridges around Mecca can be seen stretching into the distance.

The mountain still carries the marks of constant human movement. Visitors climb it every day. Paths have widened, steps have been formed, and rubbish accumulates in places. If this continues, even the physical appearance of the mountain will gradually change.

The cave too bears the effects of continual visitation.

For this reason, anyone who wishes to understand the historical setting should not imagine that what is seen today is exactly what existed fourteen hundred years ago.

The mountain remains, but its surroundings have changed.

The city below has changed even more.

Yet standing there still gives a person something that books cannot provide: a sense of distance, height, silence, stone, and the physical effort required to reach the place.

If these impressions are kept in mind, the story of Hira becomes more human and, for me, more meaningful.

One does not need to multiply legends.

The beginning of revelation is great enough in itself.

Chapter 10

The Hijrah

The migration from Mecca to Medina was not a sudden escape. It was the result of a long struggle, careful preparation, and the steady growth of opposition in Mecca.

By this time many Muslims had already left Mecca and settled in Yathrib. The people there had begun to accept Islam in increasing numbers, and the city was becoming a place where the Messenger of God could establish a community beyond the direct control of Quraysh.

The chiefs of Mecca understood the danger. If Muhammad remained in Mecca, they could continue to watch and restrict him. But if he reached Yathrib, he would no longer be merely a preacher surrounded by a persecuted minority. He would have a city, allies, and the possibility of building an organised society.

For this reason the leadership of Quraysh gathered to decide what should be done.

Several proposals were discussed. Some suggested imprisonment. Others proposed expulsion. But these plans were rejected because neither would truly solve the problem. If Muhammad were imprisoned, his followers might try to rescue him. If he were expelled, he might establish himself elsewhere and become even stronger.

At last a more drastic plan was proposed: representatives from several clans would attack him together and kill him. Responsibility for his blood would then be divided among the tribes, making it difficult for Banu Hashim to avenge him against all of Quraysh.

The plan was accepted.

The Messenger of God was informed of the danger and began preparing to leave Mecca.

Ali ibn Abi Talib, peace be upon him, remained behind. The Messenger of God entrusted him with property that people had deposited with him for safekeeping. Even those who opposed Muhammad still trusted his honesty, and many had left valuables in his care. Ali was instructed to return these things to their owners after the Prophet's departure.

Ali also slept in the Prophet's bed.

The young men appointed to watch the house therefore believed that Muhammad was still inside. This gave the Messenger of God time to leave without being immediately detected.

The common story often presents the departure in highly dramatic terms, describing handfuls of dust thrown at the watchers and miraculous concealment. The author, however, prefers to understand the event through careful planning and the realities of the city.

Mecca contained many lanes, houses, courtyards, and routes of movement. A man familiar with the city, especially one protected by loyal relatives and friends, did not need to disappear supernaturally in order to leave unseen.

The important fact is that he escaped the planned assassination.

Why South Instead of North?

Medina lies to the north of Mecca. Yet the Messenger of God first travelled south, toward Jabal Thawr.

This was not strange. It was exactly what a careful traveller should do if he expected pursuit.

The Quraysh naturally assumed that Muhammad would take the northern road. By moving first in the opposite direction, he confused the search and bought valuable time.

He did not travel alone.

Abu Bakr accompanied him.

Arrangements had also been made for food, information, and transport. The journey therefore shows planning rather than panic.

The Messenger of God and Abu Bakr remained in the area of Thawr for a period before beginning the longer route toward Medina.

Later narrators surrounded this stage of the Hijrah with stories of a spider spinning a web over the cave, pigeons laying eggs at the entrance, and pursuers turning away because they believed no one could have entered.

The Qur'an does not mention any of these details.

It mentions the cave and the two men within it, and it records the Messenger of God saying to his companion:

“Do not grieve; indeed, God is with us.”

That is enough to establish the seriousness of the danger and the confidence of the Messenger of God.

The author therefore sees no need to rely on later embellishment. The actual event was remarkable enough: the most wanted man in Mecca left the city under threat of death, avoided those searching for him, and began the journey that would transform Arabia.

The Route to Medina

The route from Mecca to Medina was known to merchants, tribesmen, shepherds, and guides. Caravans had travelled it for generations.

But a man being pursued would not necessarily remain on the main road.

The Messenger of God therefore employed a guide who knew less obvious routes. The party moved along paths that reduced the likelihood of interception.

Travel through western Arabia was difficult. The ground alternated between rocky hills, open plains, dry valleys, and stretches of sand. Water was not always easy to obtain, and travellers had to know where wells and settlements lay.

Camels made the journey possible, but even by camel it was not easy. Heat, thirst, fatigue, and the danger of attack accompanied every long-distance journey.

The Messenger of God had travelled in this broader region before. He was not unfamiliar with caravan life or the geography of Arabia.

The Hijrah should therefore not be imagined as the journey of a helpless fugitive who depended only on miracles. It was the movement of a leader who understood travel, people, and danger and who used every practical means available to him.

Suraqah ibn Malik

One of the best-known incidents during the journey concerns Suraqah ibn Malik.

When Quraysh discovered that Muhammad had escaped, they announced a reward for anyone who captured him.

Suraqah learned that a small group of travellers had been seen in the distance. Suspecting that they might include Muhammad, he set out after them.

According to the traditional account, as he approached, his horse repeatedly stumbled or sank into the ground. He then became frightened and realised that he would not succeed in harming the Messenger of God.

He called out and asked for protection.

The Messenger of God granted it.

The report then says that the Prophet promised Suraqah that one day he would wear the bracelets of Kisra, the ruler of Persia.

The author treats some of these details cautiously.

That Suraqah pursued the travellers is entirely plausible. That he later abandoned the pursuit and received protection is also possible. But the more elaborate prophetic details require examination, especially when they appear mainly in sources written long after the event.

Again, the important historical fact is clear: pursuit did occur, and the travellers escaped it.

The Journey Through the Desert

As the party moved northward, they passed through lands occupied or controlled by different tribes.

Some settlements offered water and hospitality. In other places the travellers had to rely on the supplies they carried.

The Messenger of God met people along the way, and some later became associated with well-known traditions.

Among these is the story of Umm Ma'bad, a woman whose tent stood near the route.

The traditional narrative says that the travellers asked her for food. She had nothing available except a thin goat that had stopped giving milk. The Messenger of God touched the animal, prayed, and it suddenly produced enough milk for everyone.

The story is beautiful and widely repeated.

The author, however, places it in the same category as many other later accounts. The journey unquestionably involved hospitality from people living along the route, but extraordinary details should not be accepted merely because they are familiar.

A traveller in Arabia depended heavily on the generosity of tents and settlements along the road. Milk, dates, water, and bread were the ordinary provisions offered to strangers.

Thus a simple act of hospitality could easily become, in later storytelling, a miraculous episode.

Arrival Near Medina

The people of Yathrib had heard that the Messenger of God was on his way.

Every day some of them went outside the city and waited.

They watched the roads, hoping to see the travellers appear.

When the heat became severe around midday, they would return home and come out again later.

At last news spread that Muhammad had arrived.

The people came out in great numbers to receive him.

Children, women, men, and elders gathered along the road. The arrival was not merely the welcome of an honoured guest. For the believers of Yathrib, it marked the arrival of the man around whom their new community would be formed.

The Messenger of God first stopped at Quba, a settlement on the outskirts of Medina.

He remained there for a short time.

Ali, peace be upon him, who had stayed behind in Mecca to return the entrusted property and complete other responsibilities, later joined him.

The reunion must have been deeply significant. Ali had carried one of the most dangerous responsibilities in Mecca, remaining behind after the Messenger of God had escaped, sleeping in his bed, and facing the possibility of attack.

Once he had completed his duties, he too made the journey to Medina.

Quba

Quba lay to the south of Medina and was inhabited by people who had already accepted Islam.

The Messenger of God stayed there before entering the central settlement.

A mosque was established at Quba. It is often described as the first mosque founded in Islam after the Hijrah.

In later centuries the building was repeatedly enlarged and rebuilt, so the structure visible today should not be confused with the simple mosque of the earliest period.

The original mosque would have been modest, suited to the materials and needs of a small settlement.

The Messenger of God remained at Quba only briefly.

Then he continued toward Medina.

Entering Medina

The people of Medina wanted the Messenger of God to stay with them.

As he entered the city, different families came forward and invited him to their homes.

Each wished to receive the honour of hosting him.

The Messenger of God did not wish to create rivalry by choosing one family over another. He therefore allowed his camel to proceed and said that it had been commanded where to stop.

The animal eventually knelt at a particular place.

Nearby lived Abu Ayyub al-Ansari.

The Messenger of God stayed in his house.

This account reflects an important social problem. Medina contained several clans, each conscious of its own honour. If the Messenger of God had personally chosen one household, jealousy could easily have arisen. By allowing the camel's stopping place to determine the matter, he avoided unnecessary competition.

At the same time, the place where the camel knelt later became associated with the building of the Prophet's Mosque.

The Prophet's Mosque

The land on which the mosque was built belonged to two orphan boys.

The Messenger of God insisted that the land be purchased rather than simply taken.

The mosque was then constructed with simple materials.

Its walls were made from mud brick or similar local material. Palm trunks served as pillars, and palm branches formed the roof.

The floor was earth.

There was no dome, no minaret, no marble courtyard, and no elaborate decoration.

It was a place of prayer, gathering, teaching, consultation, and public affairs.

The simplicity of the first mosque is important because later generations often imagine the earliest Islamic community through the architecture of later centuries.

In reality, the centre from which a new society was organised was materially very modest.

Yet from this simple structure came decisions that affected the whole of Arabia.

The Houses Beside the Mosque

Rooms were built beside the mosque for the household of the Messenger of God.

These rooms were small and simple.

As the Prophet married, different wives had separate rooms or quarters.

The mosque and these dwellings were closely connected.

People came continually to ask questions, seek judgment, learn, pray, or consult the Messenger of God.

There was therefore little separation between his private life and the public responsibilities of leadership.

The author emphasises this point because later religious imagination often places the Messenger of God at a distance from ordinary human life.

In Medina, however, he lived among the people. His dwelling stood beside the mosque. People saw him entering and leaving, eating, speaking, resting, and dealing with everyday problems.

His leadership was not conducted from a palace.

The Ansar and the Muhajirun

The Muslims who had emigrated from Mecca became known as the Muhajirun, the Emigrants.

The Muslims of Medina who received and supported them became known as the Ansar, the Helpers.

The arrival of the Muhajirun created practical difficulties.

Many had left property, homes, and businesses behind in Mecca. Some arrived with little more than what they could carry.

The people of Medina therefore helped them with housing, food, land, and work.

The Messenger of God established bonds of brotherhood between members of the two groups.

The purpose was not merely ceremonial. It was a practical way of integrating the newcomers into the economic and social life of Medina.

The Ansar shared resources, while the Muhajirun gradually entered trade, agriculture, and other work.

This was necessary if the new community was to survive.

A religious movement cannot live on emotion alone. People must eat, work, own property, settle disputes, and organise social relations.

The Medinan period therefore brought Islam into a new phase.

Medina Before Islam

Medina was very different from Mecca.

Mecca was primarily a commercial and pilgrimage centre.

Medina was an agricultural oasis.

Date palms covered large parts of the surrounding land. Wells provided water. Families owned gardens, fields, and fortified dwellings.

The city was not a single compact urban settlement in the modern sense. It consisted of clusters of houses, tribal quarters, cultivated land, and defensive structures spread across the oasis.

The principal Arab tribes were Aws and Khazraj.

Jewish tribes also lived in and around the oasis and possessed land, fortresses, and commercial influence.

The Arabs of Medina had experienced prolonged conflict before the arrival of the Messenger of God, especially between Aws and Khazraj.

The Battle of Bu'ath, fought not long before the Hijrah, had weakened both sides.

This history helps explain why many people in Medina were ready for a new form of leadership.

They were tired of tribal warfare.

The Messenger of God arrived at a moment when the city needed someone capable of creating a broader political order.

A New Political Community

The Hijrah therefore marks more than a change of residence.

In Mecca, the Messenger of God had preached within a society controlled by others.

In Medina, he became the centre of an organised community.

Religious, political, social, military, and economic questions now had to be addressed together.

The Muslims had to determine relations among themselves, relations with the Jewish tribes, relations with neighbouring tribes, and relations with Quraysh in Mecca.

The Messenger of God therefore began creating agreements.

Among the most important was the document often called the Constitution of Medina.

It established principles concerning mutual defence, the rights and responsibilities of different groups, the settlement of disputes, and the political unity of the city.

The document recognised that different communities could retain their own religion while belonging to a shared political order.

This was an important development.

The new society was not built merely by commanding everyone to become identical. It was built by defining obligations and limits within which different groups could coexist.

Why the Hijrah Matters

The Islamic calendar later began from the Hijrah rather than from the birth of the Messenger of God or from the beginning of revelation.

This choice is significant.

The Hijrah marks the point at which Islam moved from persecution to organised public life.

Before it, Muslims were a vulnerable community in Mecca.

After it, they possessed a centre, laws, alliances, institutions, and the ability to defend themselves.

The migration was therefore not simply a journey from one city to another.

It was the beginning of a new historical phase.

For that reason, anyone who wishes to understand Islam must understand the Hijrah not only as a sacred memory but as an act of political intelligence, courage, social organisation, and practical leadership.

The Messenger of God left Mecca under threat of death.

He arrived in Medina as the leader of a community.

The caravans had begun to move in a new direction.

Chapter 11

The House of the Messenger of God

The house associated with the Messenger of God stood within a large enclosure. In Urdu, such a place might be described as a walled compound. It lay in the old quarter of Banu Hashim, on the eastern side of the Haram. In earlier times this entire neighbourhood belonged to Abd al-Muttalib and his descendants.

As the centuries passed, the old arrangement of the quarter disappeared and its buildings were repeatedly altered. Yet from the surviving descriptions it is possible to form some idea of its original layout. The enclosure was roughly rectangular. A large gate opened at the front, while another entrance stood along one of the side walls. Inside were several rooms built against the outer walls, with an open courtyard between them.

The house itself was not large by modern standards. Its length and width were modest, and its rooms were simple. Like most houses in Mecca at that time, it was designed for the climate and for family life rather than for display.

After the Hijrah, the property came into the possession of Aqil ibn Abi Talib and remained with him and his descendants for some time. Later it was purchased by Muhammad ibn Yusuf al-Thaqafi and incorporated into a larger residence. Over the centuries, further construction altered the area until the original form could no longer be recognised.

The houses of Abu Talib, the Messenger of God, and other members of Banu Hashim once stood close to one another in this same neighbourhood. The lanes between them were narrow, and the whole quarter formed part of the old residential centre of Mecca.

Suq al-Layl

Near this quarter was the market known as Suq al-Layl. It existed in the time of the Messenger of God and was connected with the property of Abu Talib.

When I visited Mecca about thirty-five years ago, the market still existed and retained something of its old form. If one came from the direction of the place associated with the birth of the Messenger of God, the market began nearby and extended for some distance toward the north.

Today the old market has largely disappeared beneath new construction. Yet shops still occupy the area, and men and women continue to buy and sell there. In earlier times the

market provided the ordinary necessities of life: cloth, perfumes, household goods, food, and other items needed by the people of Mecca and by travellers.

The market extended in the direction of Jannat al-Mu'alla and remained active into later centuries. Because trade often continued there into the night, it became known as Suq al-Layl, the Night Market.

Mecca also had separate markets for animals. There were places where camels, horses, sheep, and other livestock were bought and sold, as well as markets in which slaves were traded. Travellers arriving from outside the city would pass through such commercial areas before entering the central quarters of Mecca.

Other important markets were held outside Mecca. Among them were Ukaz, Majanna, and Dhu al-Majaz. These were not merely places of buying and selling. They were also meeting places where tribes gathered, poets recited their compositions, alliances were discussed, and news spread from one part of Arabia to another.

Commercial life was therefore inseparable from the social life of Mecca.

People came to the city for many reasons. Some came for worship, some for trade, some for tribal gatherings, and some for all these purposes together. It would be wrong to imagine that every visitor came solely for religious devotion. The pilgrimage season also created one of the largest commercial gatherings in Arabia.

Arafat

Arafat lies to the east of Mecca, about twenty kilometres from the city. It is a broad plain surrounded by low mountains. During Hajj, pilgrims gather there on the ninth of Dhu al-Hijjah, and the standing at Arafat is one of the essential rites of the pilgrimage.

Within the plain rises the hill now known as Jabal al-Rahmah. It is a beautiful rocky hill, approximately sixty metres high. Large stones form its slopes, and because of the constant movement of visitors, steps have been made to make the ascent easier.

A white pillar stands near its summit and has become one of the most recognisable features of the hill. From there one can look across the vast plain of Arafat.

The place associated with the standing of the Messenger of God during his final Hajj lies within this broader area. After the noon prayer, he mounted his camel and proceeded to the place of standing, where he remained facing the qiblah until sunset.

On the day of Arafat, the entire plain is filled with pilgrims. At other times, however, it can appear almost empty. The Saudi government has planted many trees in the area, changing its appearance considerably from what it must have been in earlier centuries.

From a distance, Jabal al-Rahmah rises like a spear from the plain. When the surrounding mountains are viewed together, the valley between them forms a natural open basin. Stairs now lead up the hill, and visitors climb toward the white pillar.

The landscape has been altered by roads, construction, and the movement of millions of pilgrims, yet the broad shape of the plain remains visible. To stand there is to gain some sense of the geography through which the Messenger of God and the early Muslims moved during the rites of Hajj.

Modern facilities now surround the area, and during the pilgrimage season temporary services, food stalls, and other arrangements appear everywhere. Yet beneath these additions lies the same plain that has drawn pilgrims for centuries.

Chapter 12

The Market of Hadar Kashab and the Odes of Imru' al-Qays

Travel about four hundred kilometres south of Medina and roughly one hundred and fifty kilometres east of Mecca, and you come to a small settlement known as Hadar Kashab. Around it stretches the desert, broken here and there by red and black hills. Their colour is so deep, and the red so dark, that they look as though they have been scorched by fire.

In earlier days there were small dwellings here, with grape gardens nearby. Low fences or walls stood around them. Rain sometimes fell, and water would run down from the surrounding ground, but water was never abundant. The people therefore lived simply and made use of whatever the land could provide.

When I first went there, about twenty-five years ago, the settlement still consisted largely of spacious courtyards enclosed by low stone walls and simple houses with wooden doors. The people were remarkably hospitable. If a traveller entered their homes, they would offer food and water with great warmth. Their way of life was plain, but there was a generosity in it that remained in my memory.

A large market once stood here. It was enclosed by a wall and had shops arranged along its sides. In ancient times this market was used for public gatherings and, according to local tradition, for poetry contests. Poets came from different parts of Arabia and recited before the assembled people. Imru' al-Qays and other celebrated poets were associated with this world of public recitation.

Poetry in Arabia was not merely written literature. It was performed. A poet stood before an audience and recited in a particular rhythm and tone. The people listened closely, and the excellence of a poem was judged by its language, imagery, music, and force. The finest verses were remembered and repeated from tribe to tribe. Poetry preserved honour, shame, love, war, genealogy, journeys, and the memory of places that would otherwise have vanished.

A good poet could move an entire gathering. His words were not read silently from a page; they were heard in the open air, among men who understood every turn of phrase. The rhythm of the voice, the pauses, and the rise and fall of the recitation were all part of the poem itself.

It is difficult for those of us who encounter classical Arabic poetry only in books to imagine this atmosphere. One must picture the market crowded with tribesmen, merchants, travellers, and poets, the desert lying beyond them, and a voice rising above the gathering to recite lines that listeners might remember for the rest of their lives.

The following verses convey something of that world:

Whose deserted halting-place is this, beneath the moon and stars?
The people have left the settlement, and even the scene has fallen silent.

The moonlight played across the red hills,
while the eye watched the beloved sink beyond them.

The caravan disappeared into the distance; only the sound remained,
and night spread its dark covering over the back of the last camel.

The city square lies empty; the fire has gone out and darkness has descended.
Even your wanderers sit among the travellers tonight.

No one has ever measured the road of those who walk upon the sand;
with the next step, the mark of the one before it is erased.

Once, while rain was falling there, I stood looking across the place and felt as though time had suddenly moved backward. The modern world seemed to fall away. I imagined the old caravans, the poets, the tents, and the gatherings that had once filled these now-quiet spaces.

A place that appears empty today may once have been alive with commerce, argument, poetry, and movement. The desert does not preserve buildings well, but it preserves memory in another way. A road, a hill, or a ruined market can suddenly bring an entire vanished age before the mind.

Another Incident from the Same Period

Around the same period, I had another experience in Saudi Arabia that I still remember vividly.

I had come on an Umrah visa, but like many young men who travelled there in those days, I was also trying to earn some money. At one point I was working in a hotel, doing whatever work was available. One day an Arab official approached me and asked what I was doing there.

I showed him my passport. The moment he saw that I had entered on an Umrah visa, the situation changed.

He told me to come with him.

I was taken to a building where a number of other foreigners were being held. Some were Pakistanis; others came from different parts of Asia and Africa. Most had been detained because they were working without the proper residence or employment documents.

I had never before seen such a gathering. Men from many countries sat together, all waiting to learn what would happen next. Some had lived in Saudi Arabia for years. Others, like me, had arrived only recently. A few spoke Urdu or Punjabi, and I was therefore able to talk with them.

One man explained that people were often arrested in this way and then moved from one place to another until the authorities decided whether to release or deport them. He advised me not to become frightened. “Whatever happens,” he said, “happens to everyone here. Wait and see.”

We were given food and allowed to pray. Afterward we were moved again.

At another holding place I met men who had been working in shops, hotels, garages, and construction. Some had proper employers but no papers with them at the time of arrest. Others had overstayed their visas. A few had been earning money secretly for months.

The experience was humiliating, but it was also strangely educational. I had come to Arabia with my mind filled with history, sacred places, and the world of the early Muslims. Suddenly I was seeing another Arabia: immigration officers, labourers, detention rooms, police vehicles, and men trying to survive far from home.

From the windows of the vehicle that carried us, I kept looking at the country outside. Mountains stretched into the distance. Their bare slopes seemed to go on without end. Even in the middle of my anxiety, the landscape drew my attention.

At one place we were made to sit in a yard for a long time. The sun was strong, and everyone was tired. A man beside me kept asking when we would be released. No one knew.

Eventually my situation was examined more carefully. I was not treated as a criminal, but I understood clearly that an Umrah visa did not permit me to work. The uncertainty of those hours taught me more about the practical realities of migrant life than any book could have done.

During this period I also saw how easily poor workers could be exploited. A man might be promised employment, travel a great distance, hand his documents to another person, and then discover that he had no legal protection. If a dispute arose, he could lose his wages and still be the one taken into custody.

Many of the men I met were simply trying to support their families. Their lives had little of the glamour that people at home sometimes imagined when speaking of work in the Gulf. They lived in cramped rooms, worked long hours, and saved whatever they could.

These experiences remained in my mind beside the historical Arabia I was trying to understand. One Arabia belonged to books and memory; the other stood directly before me.

After several anxious days, the immediate difficulty passed. I was able to continue my journey, but I had become much more cautious. I no longer moved through the country with the careless confidence of a newly arrived traveller.

Departure for Medina and an Interesting Incident

At last I decided to leave for Medina.

I had wanted to go there from the beginning, but after what had happened I was afraid that another check of my papers might create trouble. Still, the desire to see Medina was stronger than my fear.

In those days buses travelled regularly between Mecca and Medina. The journey was far less comfortable than it is now. The road was narrower, the vehicles were simpler, and the long stretches between settlements felt much more isolated.

I bought a ticket and boarded a bus.

At first my heart was uneasy. Whenever we approached a checkpoint, I wondered whether someone would ask to see my passport and whether I would again be detained. Nothing happened at the first few stops, and gradually I began to relax.

The fare from Mecca to Medina was about forty-five riyals.

The passengers were a mixed group: Arabs, Pakistanis, Indians, Africans, and people from other countries. Some were pilgrims, some workers, and some ordinary travellers. Bags, parcels, food, and water were packed around us in the usual fashion of long-distance bus travel.

The distance from Mecca to Medina is about 550 kilometres. Today much of the journey is made on a broad modern motorway, but the road I travelled then was very different. It

passed through mountain country and long barren stretches where one could see little except stone, sand, and sky.

The landscape changed gradually as we moved north.

In some places the mountains were brown and dry; elsewhere the ground was covered in black volcanic rock. Great fields of dark stone stretched across the land as though fire had once poured over it and then suddenly hardened.

This volcanic country is one of the striking features of the region around Medina. Anyone travelling through it for the first time cannot easily forget it. The blackness of the rock, especially near sunset, gives the land a severe and ancient appearance.

At intervals we stopped at small settlements or roadside places where passengers could buy water and food. People climbed down, stretched their legs, prayed, and returned to the bus.

At one stop a small incident occurred that caused me considerable anxiety. There was confusion about tickets and papers, and for a few moments I thought I had again fallen into difficulty with the authorities. A fellow passenger helped explain the matter, and the problem was resolved.

Such incidents seem small afterward, but when one is young, alone in a foreign country, and uncertain of the language and the law, even a minor misunderstanding can feel enormous.

The road continued through the mountains.

I watched the scenery constantly. I had read the names of these regions in books, but now I was passing through the land itself. Somewhere across these same broad spaces caravans had travelled between Mecca and Medina for centuries. Armies had passed, merchants had carried goods, and pilgrims had crossed the desert long before modern roads existed.

By evening the light had begun to fade.

The black rocks and mountains became silhouettes against the sky. The bus moved steadily northward, and I knew that Medina could no longer be very far away.

I cannot forget the feeling that came over me as we drew nearer.

For years Medina had existed in my mind as a sacred name. Now it was becoming a real city at the end of a real road.

I spent that night in Medina.

At that time the city was not nearly as large as it is today. Many of the modern buildings and extended residential areas did not yet exist. The bus station stood relatively close to the older part of the city, and the surroundings were much simpler.

After arriving, I made my way toward the Mosque of the Messenger of God.

I entered through Bab Jibril.

For a moment I stood still.

The journey from Mecca, the mountains, the black volcanic fields, the fear of checkpoints, the uncertainty of travel - all of it seemed to fall behind me.

I had reached Medina.

Chapter 13

The Story of Medina

I first went to Medina twenty-eight years ago. At that time, Saudi Arabia imposed many restrictions on visitors, and people were not allowed to enter certain places freely. I had no special permit, yet I was determined to see as much as I could. I was young, curious, and deeply interested in the history of the city.

Much of old Medina still survived then in narrow lanes and old houses. The doors and windows were small, and in some places one could still see the kind of simple architecture that belonged to an earlier age. In several quarters there were houses built with mud and stone, their wooden doors opening into shaded courtyards. I walked through these neighbourhoods for hours, looking closely at anything that might preserve some trace of the older city.

Medina had, of course, changed greatly by then. Modern buildings had already begun to replace older ones, yet one could still find parts of the city that seemed to belong to another time. Some houses had small rooms opening around central courtyards. In others, the upper storeys projected over the narrow lanes. The deeper I went into the old quarters, the more strongly I felt that one could still recover something of the city's earlier appearance.

I was especially interested in the places connected with the household of the Messenger of God. The old quarters around the Prophet's Mosque had changed again and again over the centuries, and many original sites had been absorbed into later construction. Even so, I believed that the ground itself had a history and that, where buildings had disappeared, careful investigation could still bring some of that history to light.

Today much more has vanished. The old lanes I once walked through have largely disappeared beneath modern expansion. The city has been rebuilt on a scale that has made it far more difficult to recognise the Medina of earlier generations.

My First Night in Medina

My first night in Medina was difficult.

I had arrived late and had nowhere to stay. I knew no one in the city. I walked for some time with my small bag, wondering where I could spend the night. The hotels were beyond what I could afford, and I did not want to waste the little money I had.

Eventually I found a modest place where I was allowed to rest. The arrangements were simple, but to me they were enough. I was in Medina. That fact alone outweighed every discomfort.

The next morning I set out early.

Whenever I sat with elderly people and told them that I was researching old Medina, they would begin telling me stories. One man would mention a lane, another an old house, another a grave, a garden, a well, or some place connected with the Prophet's family. I wrote down whatever I could and then went out to see the place for myself.

At that time many such places could still be reached on foot. Some were in poor condition, but they had not yet disappeared completely.

One evening I met an elderly man who seemed especially knowledgeable. When he learned that I was looking for places associated with the Ahl al-Bayt, he asked me which names I knew.

I mentioned Umar, Abu Bakr, Zubayr, Uthman, Umm al-Mu'minin Aishah, Hazrat Talhah, Marwan, Mu'awiyah, Yazid ibn Abd al-Malik, Umar ibn Abd al-Aziz, Zayd ibn Thabit, Abu Hurayrah, and others whose names appear frequently in the histories.

Then I asked him whether he knew anything about Fatimah, Ali, Hasan, Husayn, or the children and descendants of the Messenger of God.

He looked at me with surprise.

His knowledge of those places was extremely limited.

That encounter left a deep impression on me. I realised how easily history can be preserved selectively. Entire generations can grow up surrounded by the names of some people while barely hearing the names of others.

I later told a friend about this conversation. He laughed and said, "Brother, do not waste your strength. There are things people here simply do not want remembered."

Perhaps he was right.

Still, I continued my search.

I had begun reading the histories of Medina more carefully. I tried to compare the old descriptions with the physical city. When a report mentioned a house, a lane, a well, or a burial place, I tried to determine where it had stood. At times the texts contradicted one another. At other times the modern city had erased almost every visible sign.

Yet I found that the more one studies the geography, the more questions arise.

The Caravan of My Search

One day, after the Fajr prayer, I set out again. I wanted to find the places that had been mentioned to me the night before.

I walked through the streets around the Prophet's Mosque and then farther into the older quarters. The morning air was cool, and the city had not yet become crowded. Shopkeepers were only beginning to open their doors.

In those days I often wandered without a clear guide. A place-name mentioned in a book might lead me from one street to another until someone recognised it. Sometimes I would discover that the name had changed. Sometimes people used a modern name for a place known in older histories by another.

I learned to ask several people the same question.

If three or four elderly residents gave similar directions, I took that as a useful sign. If their answers differed completely, I returned to the books and began again.

At times I walked until my feet ached. But the exhaustion did not matter. I had the feeling that every surviving trace might soon disappear.

I was not searching merely for monuments. What interested me was the life that had once existed around them: which families lived where, which roads they used, how far one house stood from another, which route led toward Quba, where gardens began, and where the old boundaries of the city lay.

Many historical arguments become clearer when one understands such distances.

A story that sounds plausible in a book may seem impossible once one walks the route described in it. Conversely, a report that appears strange in writing may become entirely understandable when one sees the geography.

For that reason I came to believe that anyone who writes about the early history of Medina should know the city not only from books but also from the ground.

The Evening Atmosphere

Of all the directions around Medina, I first turned toward the west and south-west.

In those days several old settlements still stood there. Some houses had thick walls and large courtyards. Beyond them were gardens and open spaces. Toward the outskirts one could still see traces of agricultural life.

Medina had always been an oasis city. Date palms, wells, cultivated land, and small fortified settlements formed part of its older landscape.

The city known to the Messenger of God was therefore not simply a cluster of houses around the mosque. It was a wider inhabited region broken by gardens, tribal quarters, lava fields, and cultivated land.

As evening approached, the appearance of the city changed. The light softened, the heat declined, and the old walls took on a different colour. Standing among them, one could more easily imagine the Medina of earlier centuries.

This is why the destruction of old sites troubles me. When a historical structure disappears, we lose more than stone and mud. We lose the proportions of a place, the distance between one site and another, the direction of a road, and the physical setting in which an event occurred.

A book can preserve names, but only a place preserves scale.

I continued walking until darkness began to fall.

Bayt al-Huzn, or the House of Grief

At that time I saw a house known locally as Bayt al-Huzn, the House of Grief.

It stood to the south-west of Masjid al-Nabawi, toward the old cemetery. People said that it was associated with Fatimah, peace be upon her, and that after the death of the Messenger of God she would sometimes go there in grief.

The building was not grand. It was a simple structure, and by the time I saw it, much had already changed around it.

The place opened toward the east. Nearby were old graves and paths leading through the cemetery. In earlier times the whole area would have been much more open.

I was told that the house had once been used as a place of mourning and remembrance. Whether every detail preserved in local tradition is historically exact is another question, but the association itself was old and widely known.

From there one could move toward the burial ground of al-Baqi'.

Baqi', in those days, was not arranged as it is now. The entrances, paths, and surrounding walls were different. One could still recognise more clearly the relative positions of certain graves and family burial areas.

I began to think about the period after the death of the Messenger of God.

Those days were politically turbulent. The question of leadership had immediately become a matter of dispute. Fatimah, peace be upon her, lived only a short time after her father, and the reports concerning her final months preserve intense grief and conflict.

Some historians describe her as repeatedly mourning the Messenger of God. Others preserve reports of disputes over inheritance, Fadak, and political allegiance.

The author of these pages does not regard these as isolated personal quarrels. They belong to the larger struggle over authority that followed the Prophet's death.

According to reports preserved in the historical tradition, pressure was placed upon Ali, peace be upon him, to give allegiance to the new government. Fatimah, peace be upon her, opposed what she considered an injustice and spoke publicly about her rights.

The disagreements became severe.

The reports also mention that Fatimah did not remain on friendly terms with those who had taken control of the government. She died only a few months after the Messenger of God.

Her exact burial place became uncertain.

That uncertainty is itself part of the history.

If the daughter of the Messenger of God had died in ordinary circumstances and had been buried with the public honour due to her, one would expect her grave to have been unmistakably known.

Instead, the reports say that she asked to be buried at night and that those with whom she had been in conflict were not to attend her funeral.

Her grave was therefore concealed.

This is one of the most striking facts in the early history of Medina.

The house associated with her grief, the cemetery of al-Baqi', the house of Ali, and the Prophet's Mosque all stood within a relatively small area. To walk between them is to realise how physically close the principal actors in these events were to one another.

Medina was not a vast capital. These people lived only minutes apart.

That makes the intensity of the conflict all the more significant.

The remaining traces of Bayt al-Huzn have now largely disappeared, and the area has been altered by later construction. A visitor today can easily pass through without knowing that such a place was ever associated with Fatimah.

Yet the memory remains in the historical record.

For me, that was enough to continue the search.

Chapter 14

The Burial Place of Fatimah, Daughter of the Messenger of God

It is commonly said that Fatimah, daughter of the Prophet, is buried in Jannat al-Baqi'. Visitors are often shown a place there and told that one of the graves is hers.

But this is not certain.

The exact burial place of Fatimah, peace be upon her, has remained disputed from the earliest period. Some reports place her grave in al-Baqi', while others say that she was buried in her own house. Still others preserve different possibilities.

What is beyond dispute is that her grave was deliberately not made public.

After her death, several graves were prepared or marked so that the actual burial place would not easily be identified. Ali, peace be upon him, wished to protect the location in accordance with her instructions.

This matter must be understood in the context of what happened after the death of the Messenger of God.

The people who had taken political authority came to the house of Fatimah, where Ali and several members of Banu Hashim were gathered. They wanted allegiance to be given to the new leadership.

The accounts of what followed differ in detail, but the hostility between Fatimah and those in power is difficult to deny. Her anger remained until her death.

This is why the question of her burial place is not a minor historical curiosity. It is connected with the larger political conflict that emerged immediately after the death of the Messenger of God.

A person may ask: if everything between them had been peaceful, why was her burial conducted secretly? Why were those in authority not informed? Why was the grave concealed?

These questions remain.

One of the reports says that Fatimah told Ali before her death that those who had wronged her should not attend her funeral and should not know where she was buried.

Accordingly, she was buried at night.

When the people learned in the morning that the burial had already taken place, some went toward al-Baqi' and tried to identify the grave. They found several newly prepared graves and could not determine which one was hers.

According to another report, an attempt was made to open the graves so that the burial place might be discovered.

Ali, peace be upon him, came out armed and warned them not to proceed.

The matter ended there.

Whether every detail of these reports is accepted or not, the central fact remains that Fatimah's grave was hidden and that its precise location was not publicly established.

Where, Then, Is Her Grave?

There are several possibilities.

One is that she was buried in al-Baqi'.

Another is that she was buried in the house in which she lived, close to the Mosque of the Messenger of God.

A third possibility appears in some reports linking her burial to the area between the Prophet's grave and his pulpit.

The author considers the second possibility especially important.

In the earliest period, the houses surrounding the Prophet's Mosque were extremely close to it. Later expansions absorbed many of these rooms and houses into the mosque itself.

If Fatimah was buried in her house, the grave would therefore now lie within the expanded precinct of Masjid al-Nabawi.

This would also explain why no clearly identified grave of hers remained in al-Baqi'.

The physical geography deserves attention.

Fatimah's house stood near the dwelling of the Messenger of God. Ali lived there with her. After the Prophet's death, the family remained in that same area. The distances were very small.

When later rulers enlarged the mosque, several houses belonging to the Prophet's family were demolished or incorporated into the new structure.

Thus a grave once located inside a private house could easily have become part of the mosque.

The question cannot be settled with certainty merely by pointing to a later marker in al-Baqi'.

I have repeatedly noticed that many visitors assume that every place shown to them today has been continuously and precisely identified since the seventh century. That is not how history works.

Cities change.

Buildings are demolished.

Walls move.

Graves lose their markers.

Governments rename places.

Later generations sometimes identify a site on the basis of tradition rather than continuous physical evidence.

The burial place of Fatimah is one of the most important examples.

The Historical Setting

To understand why secrecy mattered, one must return to the days immediately after the death of the Messenger of God.

The community had scarcely finished mourning when the question of succession divided it.

Ali and Banu Hashim were occupied with the Prophet's burial.

Meanwhile, others gathered at Saqifah and selected a leader.

This decision was made before the Prophet had even been buried.

When the new authority sought general allegiance, Ali and those with him did not immediately comply.

Pressure followed.

The reports concerning Fatimah's house are among the most painful in Muslim history. Some sources speak of threats to burn the house. Others report force being used at the

door. Shia sources preserve the further claim that Fatimah was injured and that the injuries contributed to her death.

Sunni historians often reject or minimise these details.

But even if one sets aside the disputed particulars, the political rupture itself remains undeniable.

Fatimah was displeased with the new rulers.

Reports found even in major Sunni collections state that she remained angry with Abu Bakr over the dispute concerning her inheritance and Fadak and did not speak to him until her death.

She lived only a short time after the Messenger of God.

Her funeral was private.

Her burial was at night.

Her grave was concealed.

These facts are sufficient to show that the relationship was not harmonious.

The historian must therefore ask what caused such bitterness between the daughter of the Messenger of God and the men who assumed political authority after him.

The question cannot be answered by simply ignoring it.

A Regrettable Incident

I remember an incident from my own visit to Medina.

I was walking near the old cemetery when I saw a Pakistani family. An elderly man was with them, and they were trying to locate a particular grave.

They asked me whether I knew where the grave of Fatimah was.

I told them that the matter was disputed and that no one could point with certainty to a single grave in al-Baqi' and say, "This is unquestionably hers."

They were surprised.

The old man said that they had always been told that her grave was here.

I explained that one view placed it in al-Baqi', while another held that she had been buried in her own house near the Prophet's Mosque.

He became thoughtful.

At that moment a local attendant heard our conversation and objected sharply. He insisted that visitors should not discuss such matters and told us to move on.

The family became frightened and left.

I remained disturbed.

Why should a historical question create such anxiety?

If a grave is uncertain, it is uncertain. Acknowledging that does not diminish anyone's faith.

On the contrary, the uncertainty itself may preserve an important truth.

Fatimah wanted her burial place concealed.

That concealment was a final statement.

It said that something had happened between her and the ruling authorities that she did not wish to be forgotten.

When people erase that conflict from history and reduce the matter to a simple question of where a grave lies, they miss the larger meaning.

A grave can be hidden, but history cannot be buried so easily.

Later I walked through the area again.

The old houses had largely disappeared. Great extensions of the mosque had covered ground once occupied by lanes, courtyards, and family dwellings. The city looked magnificent, but much of the older Medina had vanished beneath the marble.

This is the paradox of sacred cities.

As they expand to accommodate millions, the physical traces of their earliest history disappear.

Visitors gain space, comfort, and safety, but they lose the old scale of the city.

To understand what happened here, one must therefore read, walk, compare, and ask questions.

One must also be willing to live with uncertainty where the evidence does not permit certainty.

The burial place of Fatimah is such a case.

What remains certain is her dignity, her closeness to the Messenger of God, her grief after his death, her conflict with the new political order, and the secrecy of her burial.

Those facts should not be lost.

Chapter 15

The Reality of Bi'r Ghars

As for the previous day, I had wanted to see several places together, but in such a way that I could spend a good deal of time there, because the following day I was to leave Madinah for Khaybar and then proceed toward Fadak.

Early in the morning, I left my hotel and, emerging from the southern side of Masjid al-Nabawi, passed through the lanes of old Madinah until I reached the route known as Darb al-Sunnah. When the Messenger of God came from Quba and entered Madinah, he had travelled by this very route. It is therefore also called Darb al-Rasul. The route is about four and a half kilometres long. It has now been developed into an attractive pedestrian track, and small vehicles also operate along it. Elderly people, or those who find walking difficult, can use these little vehicles. They run on electric batteries and therefore make no noise. Most people are unaware of this route.

Along the way stands a fort where the chief of Banu Najjar once lived. It is now being renovated. Banu Najjar were the maternal relatives of the Messenger of God, so this entire area was, in a sense, the neighbourhood of his maternal kin. I walked around the fort once, but every route leading inside was closed. Arab forts are generally elevated and enclosed on every side. The outer walls contain only very small windows, and in some places there are narrow slits or openings. Travelling along this route, I stopped at various places and tried to imagine the historical scenes that had existed in the time of the Messenger of God.

This is also the route by which one can reach the Well of Ghars. After travelling about four kilometres, I turned toward Bi'r Ghars. Ghars is a large well whose water is sweet and clear. Around it is a mechanism by which water used to be drawn, while on one side there is also a place from which water could be drawn with a water-skin. The well, however, was used more for meeting the needs of crops and date groves than for drinking. There was therefore also an arrangement for drawing water by animal power. The camel performed the same kinds of tasks that oxen do in our Punjab, such as ploughing and watering fields.

The place where this well stands was once a Jewish area. A fort belonging to the Jewish tribe of Banu Qurayzah stood directly opposite it. A ring road has now been built between this well and the former settlement of Banu Qurayzah. Today the marks left by the hoofs of camels can still be seen there. I photographed them.

When the Messenger of God arrived during the Hijrah and stayed at Quba, water from this well was brought for him to drink. The Messenger of God greatly liked the water of this well. At that time there were many wells in Madinah whose water was used for drinking, bathing, and washing clothes and utensils. Because of the high mineral content, however, the water of those wells was somewhat saline. This was naturally difficult for a person newly arrived in Madinah, whereas the water of this well was sweet.

At that time Madinah was a city surrounded, both within and without, by orchards. The entire region was filled with date palms, which is why it was known as a land of date groves. There were also so many wells in Madinah because water was needed to irrigate those palms. People kept wells on their own properties for that purpose. The Well of Ghars lies about five kilometres from Madinah, so its water was brought from there every day in containers for drinking.

When the passing of the Messenger of God drew near, he instructed that I should be washed with the water of the Well of Ghars and that seven water-skins should be used. 'Ali عليه السلام carried out the command of the Messenger of God. This also shows that the responsibility for the washing, shrouding, and burial of the Messenger of God rested with 'Ali عليه السلام, while the Companions of the Messenger were occupied with Saqifah.

When I reached this place for ziyarat, a Sunni Shi'a scholar had also arrived with his caravan. We spoke for a while, and he said, "Recite something here." I then recited a qasidah about 'Ali عليه السلام. People gathered, and a celebration in honour of Amir al-Ka'inat began at the Well of Ghars. Seeing the well, the excitement, and the gathering, our Sunni brothers could not understand what was happening or why people were repeatedly exclaiming in appreciation. Those poor brothers are in much the same position themselves. They too bow before sacred places and possess an awareness of ziyarat, yet the places connected with the Ahl al-Bayt of the Messenger are being made to disappear. This has been the same dispute for thousands of years.

From there I set out again and came toward the house of Imam Zayn al-'Abidin عليه السلام, where the orchard attributed to Salman al-Farsi is also located. This orchard and house lie about two kilometres north of Bi'r Ghars and approximately eight kilometres from Masjid al-Nabawi.

The situation was that the orchard now found here did not previously exist; the surrounding land was empty. Madinah itself was much the same at that time. If one wished to cultivate crops or plant an orchard, one first had to dig a well. Digging wells in Madinah was no easy task. The ground beneath the mountains is rocky, and breaking through it continuously with tools is extremely arduous work. After coming to Madinah, however, 'Ali عليه السلام adopted the occupation of digging wells and, alongside it, bringing

barren lands under cultivation. He became so proficient at this work that he could dig even the most difficult well within ten days. He would then prepare the land, plant orchards and crops, irrigate them with the water of the well, and afterwards place the land in someone else's hands. For this reason, Banu Umayyah used to taunt 'Ali عليه السلام by calling him a digger of wells. In connection with this same activity, he dug seven wells at one place in Wadi Yanbu'. Five of them he dedicated as waqf for the benefit of pilgrims entering ihram, while he retained two for his own agricultural work.

The case of Salman al-Farsi was that his Jewish master did not give him an opportunity to remain in the company of the Messenger of God. For this reason, he was unable to participate even in the battles of Badr and Uhud. Eventually Salman al-Farsi said to the Messenger of God, "O Messenger of God, free me from this Jew." The Messenger of God told him, "Ask your master the price of your freedom."

When Salman asked him, the man, out of obstinacy, demanded as the price of freeing Salman from slavery three hundred date palms and forty uqiyyahs of gold. The gold was not difficult to obtain, but the condition involving the orchard was severe. The Messenger of God took 'Ali عليه السلام and Salman with him and came to this very place, where the orchard still exists today. It lies near the fort of Banu Qurayzah. He marked out one location and told 'Ali, "Dig a well here," while telling Salman, "Prepare the land for planting date palms."

Both men set to work. When the well had been completed and the land was also ready, the Messenger of God told the Companions, "Help Salman, and provide date-palm saplings for planting in the pits." The Ansar contributed according to their ability: some gave ten nursery plants, others fifteen, and others different amounts, until the full number of three hundred had been assembled.

The Messenger of God then returned with 'Ali and Salman, and the planting began. The Messenger of God would place each nursery plant into the pit with his own hands, Mawla 'Ali would water it immediately, and Salman would pack the soil around it. In this manner all three hundred plants were completed. They then waited for five months. The purpose of waiting was to ensure that if any tree dried out, a new one could be planted in its place. All the plants remained green. They were then shown to Salman al-Farsi's master. He accepted them, and Salman al-Farsi was freed.

When the Battle of the Trench took place and Banu Qurayzah, because of their breach of covenant, received their severe punishment, the Messenger of God gave this orchard, this well, and the adjoining farmland into the ownership of 'Ali. From that time onward, the orchard and well remained with the Ahl al-Bayt of the Messenger, who cultivated the land. Imam Hasan عليه السلام and Imam Husayn عليه السلام also came here and worked,

although most of their time of residence was spent at Bayt al-Huzn and Juhaynah. When Imam Zayn al-'Abidin عليه السلام returned from Karbala, he settled permanently here rather than in Madinah itself. After him, Imam Baqir عليه السلام, and then Imam Ja'far al-Sadiq عليه السلام, likewise remained at this same place.

Shi'as arriving from Kufa, Basrah, Yanbu', and other places would also come and stay here. It pleased me to think that here I too had become a guest of Imam Zayn al-'Abidin عليه السلام, Imam Baqir عليه السلام, and Imam Ja'far al-Sadiq عليه السلام. Even today I remained here for three or four hours and experienced great tranquillity.

Among the date palms are fields of vegetables through which water is flowing. A tube well has been installed in the middle, running at full force, and its water is being directed toward the fields. The atmosphere is exceedingly pleasant. Even now, those who work here and those who sell dates are Shi'a, although as a precaution they do not openly declare their beliefs to everyone. Yesterday, however, they revealed their views to me. They fed me dajaj mandi and sold me dates that normally cost forty-five riyals per kilogram for thirty riyals. I also bought seedless dates from there.

Throughout Makkah and Madinah, although Imam Husayn عليه السلام, Imam Hasan عليه السلام, and Bibi Fatimah عليها السلام lived there, neither their names nor the names of their families are recorded at any place. Even where locations are attributed to them, their names have not been written there. The people living here now merely know that such-and-such a place is historical. There is, however, one half-road named after 'Ali ibn Abi Talib عليه السلام, and that is all.

The area behind this orchard and house is known as Qubawali, meaning "the people of 'Ali." It is a very large district. Shi'a Sayyids once lived throughout it. I travelled through it and saw that, across Madinah, they were poor people; the condition of their houses alone makes this apparent. In Madinah and its outskirts, they had effectively been subjected to a social and economic boycott, resembling the boycott in Shi'b Abi Talib. Ten years ago they sold this entire area into government hands and moved away to a newly established town north of Madinah. In effect, the authorities removed them from here and completely eliminated Shirk from Madinah. The government has begun demolishing the houses in this area so that elite-class hotels may be built for the pilgrims.

The few Shi'as who still remain in Madinah are poor people who work in car workshops. Until one becomes completely certain of them, they appear wholly ordinary and do not disclose their beliefs. The Shi'as who remain in Madinah are largely concentrated in the area between Bayt al-Huzn and Masjid Bilal. Most of the vehicle workshops are also

located there. The Shi'as of Pakistan and other countries are very fortunate in that they can openly proclaim wilayah. May God grant this opportunity to them as well.